The Noble Mahāyāna Sūtra Called The Array of the Great Liberation That Extends in All Directions, in Which Wrongdoing Is Purified by Repentance and Buddhahood Is Attained

Toh 264 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་ཐར་པ་ཆེན་པོ་ཕྱོགས་བཅུས་པ་འགྲོ་ཚངས་ཀློ་སྒྲིལ་སྡུག་བསྔལ་ཉ་ལེངས་རྒྱུ་ལ་གྱབ་པར་རྣམ་པར་བཀའ་ཡེས་བ་ཉ་ཐེག་པ་ཆེན་པའོ།།

The Noble Mahāyāna Sūtra Called The Array of the Great Liberation That Extends in All Directions, in Which Wrongdoing Is Purified by Repentance and Buddhahood Is Attained, known in Tibetan as Tharpa Chenpo Chok su Gyepa, is Toh 264 in the Kangyur, where it belongs to the General Sūtra section. Unlike most texts in the collection, it carries no Sanskrit title, because it was translated into Tibetan from Chinese, as its closing lines record. Set first in the great city of Rājagṛha before a vast assembly of monks and bodhisattvas, it is a Great Vehicle discourse on purifying misdeeds, even breaches of grave vows, through repentance, and on the path by which beings come to buddhahood. Near its close the bodhisattva Dhāraṇīdhara vows to preserve and spread the teaching, which the Buddha praises as the mother of all buddhas and the path of all bodhisattvas.

In the language of Tibet: The Noble Mahāyāna Sūtra Called The Array of the Great Liberation That Extends in All Directions, in Which Wrongdoing Is Purified by Repentance and Buddhahood Is Attained.

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was staying in the great city of Rājagṛha together with a great Saṅgha of eighty thousand monks and a Saṅgha of thirty-six thousand bodhisattvas. All of them were bound to but one more birth. They were entirely free of all obscurations, and possessed mastery of splendor and glory. With skillful means they urged the Tathāgata to teach the secret meaning. They purified buddhafields, and the deeds of a buddha came to them spontaneously. They were arrayed by the blessings of the buddhas. In order to guard and protect the collection of the Dharma, they upheld the Mahāyāna sūtras, and with a lion's roar they sounded the great thunder of the Dharma throughout the ten directions. The height of their qualities was like Mount Meru, and their wisdom, deep and vast, was like the ocean. They had subdued Māra together with his armies. They gathered in all

the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) and set their minds in purity. Being endowed with power, they were unobstructed in liberation. They dwelt at ease in sameness. They held fast to mindfulness and samādhi. They had faith in the teaching and were endowed with intelligence. Through the four means of attracting disciples, the six perfections, and immeasurable skill in means, there was no meaning of any phenomenon they did not possess. They turned the irreversible wheel in accordance with the wishes of beings. Endowed with the wisdom that knows existence and nonexistence, they were skilled in the enumerations of the Dharma. Abiding in the samādhi of the superknowledges, they understood the faculties of sentient beings with the five eyes. Of immeasurable splendor and glory, they trained the minds of many beings through meditative concentration and wisdom, and, adorned with the major marks and the excellent minor marks, they brought them to the supreme. Their minds were like space. Having entirely abandoned the forms and colors of the world, they were skilled in the nature of reality of all phenomena. With wisdom endowed with self-awareness, they knew from where to where sentient beings wander in saṃsāra. Possessing every samādhi, they attended upon the Unequalled One. Having cultivated roots of virtue for a very long time, they had attained the sovereignty of a buddha. They possessed wisdom, the ten powers, the four fearlessnesses, and the eighteen unshared qualities. They had opened the door to the good destinies and closed the doors of the lower realms. In order to show that they regard all sentient beings equally, as if each were an only child, they took birth in the five paths of rebirth and displayed bodies there. In order to free sentient beings from the afflictions, they appeared in the guise of a king of physicians and dwelt in saṃsāra; skilled in the methods of healing, they gave medicine according to the conditions of each illness and so brought beings to complete liberation from saṃsāra. They were endowed with such immeasurable qualities that there was no one who heard them and was not freed. They had made offerings to countless buddhas of the past. They thoroughly understood the essential nature of a buddha. They knew that the Tathāgata abides forever. And they constantly taught that sentient beings possess the essential nature of a buddha. All of them were such as these: the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mañjuśrī, the bodhisattva Unwavering Light, the bodhisattva Nāga Tree, the bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara, the bodhisattva Mahāsthāmaprāpta, the bodhisattva Bhaiṣajyarāja, the bodhisattva Bhaiṣajyasamudgata, the bodhisattva Samantabhadra, the bodhisattva King Lord of Dharma, the bodhisattva Siṃhanāda, the bodhisattva Dhāraṇī Holder, the bodhisattva Jewel Treasury,

the bodhisattva Ever Diligent, the bodhisattva Never Ceasing, the bodhisattva Faith in Characteristics, the bodhisattva Invincible, and the bodhisattva Maitreya, thirty-six thousand bodhisattva mahāsattvas in all. There were also eighty koṭis of niyutas of mighty gods; monks, nuns, laymen and laywomen; gods, nāgas, yakṣas, humans, nonhumans and others; and Brahmā, Śakra (Indra) and others, countless and immeasurable gods together, who were present in the sky.

They let fall a rain of the precious flowers of the gods, and countless, immeasurable cymbals and musical instruments sounded of their own accord. The god Brahmā perfumed the air with the sweet fragrance of sambhara incense, and clouds of offerings to the Tathāgata spread throughout the countless world systems of the ten directions. Offerings were presented everywhere to all the buddhas of the ten directions, to all the Dharma of the ten directions, and to all the Saṅgha of bodhisattvas of the ten directions. The gods made these offerings in order to seek the unsurpassed path of the Great Vehicle.

Then, at that time and on that occasion, the Blessed One, surrounded by that great, countless and immeasurable assembly, went together with them to where the great sāla trees stood. On the fifteenth day of the middle month of spring, on the verge of passing into nirvāṇa, through the blessing of the Tathāgata and with great loving-kindness, he resolved to gather in and protect all sentient beings. He sent forth his great voice, and that sound pervaded all ten directions; to all sentient beings, each in their own language, he declared:

"Today the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete buddha, regards sentient beings with compassion. He resolves to guard and protect sentient beings. He resolves to gather in and nurture sentient beings. Regarding sentient beings equally, as one looks upon an only child, I shall be a support for those without support. Those who have not seen the self of the Buddha I shall cause to see it. Those not free of the afflictions I shall free from them. Those without happiness I shall make happy. Those not liberated I shall liberate. Those without wealth I shall endow with wealth. Those not free of doubt I shall free from doubt. Those who have not cleansed their wrongdoing by repentance I shall cause to cleanse it by repentance."

"Those who have not passed beyond sorrow I shall bring to pass beyond sorrow." So he declared.

At that time and on that occasion, to the right and left of the road there was a level, excellent plain, entirely pure, auspicious in its land and water, ten thousand yojanas in breadth on every side. When the Blessed One saw it, he at once settled there, and he spoke these words to the monks: "This place is fit to be a ground for teaching the Dharma."

When he had said this, the monk Ānanda said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, in the past the Tathāgata has always delighted in places with mountains, groves, flowing clear water, orchards of fruit trees, and flowers. But here today there is no flowing water, no trees and no groves; there are no villages or houses, no orchards of fruit trees, and no ordinary people. Why, Blessed One, are you pleased to stay here and teach the Dharma? The multitude has come a long road, and beings tormented by the suffering of hunger and thirst cannot even keep themselves alive. If there is food, there is life; if there is life, there is a body; if there is a body, there is also the path of Dharma. If there is no food, there is no life; if there is no life, there is no body; and if there is no body, there is no path of Dharma either. That being so, and since there is nothing at all here that is agreeable in this way, why, Blessed One, do you teach the Dharma here?"

Then Śāriputra, of great wisdom, through the blessing of the Buddha said to Ānanda: "First of all, one should make requests for the sake of the Dharma; there is no need to think of anything else. The Tathāgata has not only the ten powers and the four fearlessnesses; the Tathāgata also possesses immeasurable powers, the immeasurable omniscient wisdom that is undaunted by anything, and immeasurable splendor and miraculous power. For whoever is without support, he becomes a support. Those who have not seen the essential nature of a buddha, he causes to see it. Those not free of the afflictions, he frees from the afflictions. Those without happiness, he brings to touch happiness. Those not liberated, he liberates. Those without wealth, he endows with wealth. Those who have not passed beyond sorrow, he brings completely to pass beyond sorrow. Since the Tathāgata possesses immeasurable miraculous powers such as these, what need is there to worry about the Tathāgata, as if he lacked resources of his own?

"I remember how in the past, when the great being Vimalakīrti was teaching the Dharma to a great multitude, a great multitude of bodhisattvas, śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas who had come from other world systems, together with mighty gods, nāgas and others, had gathered and were seated inside his house, and no food could be seen. At that time I thought, 'How will food be

provided for all this multitude?' Then Vimalakīrti said to me: 'Śrāvaka of lesser wisdom, you ought to be contemplating the true Dharma. Why, from the very outset, do you conceive thoughts about such illusory things as food, clothing and seats?' When the great being Vimalakīrti spoke thus, the gods and humans attained the path of Dharma, while I was ashamed. What you have just said is like that."

Then the Blessed One said to Ānanda: "Ānanda, what Śāriputra, foremost in intelligence, has said is true. One ought to think of the Great Vehicle; one should not think for the sake of the body's ease."

The moment he had said this, he entered samādhi, and instantly, through his blessing, a single golden flower sprang up there, four hundred thousand yojanas in height. It completely covered the whole thousandfold world system, and a net of beryl also spread over the golden flower. Beneath that flower appeared a jeweled bathing pool, filled to the brim with pure water possessing the eight qualities. On its four sides it was adorned with many kinds of flowers, utpalas, kumudas, padmas, puṇḍarīkas and others, immeasurable in their variety; so the jeweled pool appeared.

If anyone, merely by seeing the golden flower and the jeweled pool, attained the pure Dharma eye, what need is there to speak of entering and bathing in it? Those who entered and bathed attained purity and acceptance of the unborn nature of phenomena.

Beneath that golden flower there appeared a lion throne made of jewels, a hundred yojanas high. Then the Blessed One sat upon that jeweled throne and sent forth great rays of light from the pores of his body and from all his limbs. The light rays of the Tathāgata, matching the color of the golden flower, went out in the four directions and illuminated all the buddhafields of the ten directions. Wherever they shone, the mountains, valleys and all the lands became level, and everything turned the color of gold. No filth remained; the beings in the hells were relieved, and the hungry ghosts were also set free, all except those of perverse conduct and those who revile the true Dharma. Through the blessing of the Tathāgata, the other world systems became like this central realm, without any difference.

The buddhas of the ten directions also saw that light, and each, in words that agreed, praised the Blessed One Śākyamuni, saying "Excellent!": "Excellent, excellent! This light that the Blessed One has sent forth out of great loving-kindness is unlike the lights of the past. The light of the past first rose in

the east; today's light rose from the four directions at once and pervades the ten directions. Seeing this, it is clear that this light will lead all suffering beings out of the three realms and bring them beyond sorrow."

Then the buddhas of the ten directions each said to the bodhisattva mahāsattvas of their own retinues: "Sons of noble family, in the Sahā world system the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete buddha Śākyamuni is sending forth great rays of light; without doubt he is about to teach the true Dharma and free beings from suffering. You should go to that world system, present offerings to that buddha, ask about your doubts, and listen to and request the enumerations of the Dharma."

"The beings of that world system are all wicked and wrathful, full of lies and deceit, and they have no faith in the single vehicle. Therefore the Tathāgata Śākyamuni, out of great loving-kindness and by various skillful means, has divided it into three vehicles, and so frees them from the three realms of existence. Yet though he teaches three vehicles, his teaching is virtuous in the beginning, virtuous in the middle and virtuous in the end; excellent in meaning, excellent in wording, unadulterated, completely pure and completely spotless. That buddha, that blessed one, will not be seen again even in a hundred thousand times ten thousand eons; all the enumerations of the Dharma that he teaches will not be heard again; that assembly will not gather again; and the Blessed One Śākyamuni seated upon his throne and upon the extraordinary golden flower will not be seen again. Therefore go to that world. If you see that buddha and ask about your doubts, you yourselves will gain merit, and it will bring benefit and happiness to all people."

The moment they had said this, from each of the buddhafields of the ten directions a hundred koṭis of bodhisattvas rose from their places, bowed to their own buddhas, and set out together. Each bodhisattva carried a hundred thousand kinds of musical instruments. Letting fall a rain of the most excellent precious flowers, they went to where the Blessed One Śākyamuni was. They bowed to the Blessed One, circumambulated him seven times, and sat down to one side.

Then, each in one word, one speech and one voice, they said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, we have something to request and to ask. For the benefit and happiness of beings, we pray that the Blessed One will grant us the opportunity and explain."

Then the Blessed One said to the bodhisattvas who had come from afar: "Sons of noble family, if you have doubts, ask about all of them, and I will explain them to you in detail."

Then the bodhisattvas said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, our tathāgatas teach nothing but the single vehicle. Why, Blessed One, do you here teach three vehicles?"

Then the Blessed One, with unobstructed wisdom, said to the bodhisattvas: "Sons of noble family, it is good that you ask about such a matter for the benefit and happiness of sentient beings. Listen, sons of noble family. It is like one man who has three names: when he is little he is called a child; from the age of twenty on he is called a man; and when he is past eighty he is called an old man. My three vehicles are like that. To the śrāvakas, whose minds are of small scope, I teach the small vehicle. To the pratyekabuddhas, whose minds are of middling scope, I teach the middling vehicle. To the bodhisattva mahāsattvas who have entered the great path, I teach the Great Vehicle.

"Listen further, sons of noble family. In short, there are not two ends; they accord in a single direction. Though the doors of understanding differ, they converge on a single end. The sūtra is the single vehicle; though by the use of skillful means it is divided into three, the vehicles of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are also included within the Great Vehicle, and the Great Vehicle is the vehicle of the buddhas. Therefore the three vehicles are a single vehicle."

When this Dharma was taught, ten thousand bodhisattvas attained acceptance of the unborn nature of phenomena; eight hundred monks attained the fruit of arhatship; twenty thousand gods attained the pure Dharma eye; and a hundred thousand times ten thousand humans at once set their minds on unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening.

Then the bodhisattvas who had come from the ten directions bowed with joined palms toward where the Blessed One was, and said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, by the power and blessing of the Tathāgata we have come to this realm, and besides seeing the face of the Blessed One we have heard the Dharma of the Great Vehicle. We pray that you will permit us to take up this enumeration of the Dharma and to retain it. After the Tathāgata has passed into nirvāṇa, in this world system and in other world systems, on mountains, in forests, in groves and at the foot of trees, in the abodes of vidyādharas, in villages, towns and market towns, in districts, in hermitages, in charnel

grounds, at stūpas, in temples, in the dwellings of the Saṅgha, in places where many gather to teach the Dharma, and in the dwellings of householders, house by house, we will spread it widely and without interruption. Why? Because if this enumeration of the Dharma remains for a long time, all the lower realms will be closed off. We have heard that in the past, through what the Tathāgata taught, the door of the hells was cut off for beings. If anyone recites even a single phrase of this sūtra, the gods too feel great joy and delight; they will always honor and serve that person, and that person will naturally practice virtue.

"If anyone hears this sūtra of the Great Liberation That Extends in All Directions and, with joy arising, with a mind of faith and devotion, writes it down or has it written down, reads it, recites it, takes it up, or keeps it; or if, bowing down, they utter even one name of a buddha or one name of a bodhisattva in this enumeration of the Dharma, that person will find happiness in this very life and will not meet with misdeeds. And when their life is exhausted and they die and pass on, we bodhisattvas will go before them to lead the way, and we will cause them to be born together with us in a single place in our pure world systems. Why? Because they have taken up and retained this sūtra. To take up and retain this sūtra is to hold the body of the Buddha. Those who hold the body of the Buddha are manifestly bodhisattvas; therefore they share one training with us. For that cause and condition, we pray that those who retain this sūtra may be born together with us in one place and never be separated from us."

Then Great Brahmā, the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three, the Four Great Kings who protect the world, Vajrapāṇi the Lord of Secrets, the great yakṣa general Saṃjñeya and others, the nāga kings Nanda and Upananda, the asuras, the garuḍas, Sarasvatī, the mother Hārītī, the gods of the mountains, the gods of the trees, the gods of the rivers, the gods of the lakes, the gods of the earth, the gods of the waters, the gods of fire, the gods of the wind, and others, countless and immeasurable, rose from their seats, joined their palms toward where the Blessed One was, bowed respectfully, and said to the Blessed One:

"Blessed One, we will always guard and uphold this sūtra of the Great Liberation That Extends in All Directions taught by the Blessed One. Wherever this sūtra is kept, we will always sweep the area before it and keep it completely clean. Whether this sūtra is kept in a stūpa, in a dwelling, in the house of a householder or in a hermitage, if any person holds this sūtra with

unclean hands, or reads it or recites it without respect, we will make that person uneasy in body and mind in all four modes of conduct: walking, standing, sitting and lying down. Wherever they stay, we will bring fear and terror and sudden harm upon them. In this life they will have every kind of misery, and when they die they will fall into the hells.

"But if anyone shows respect to this sūtra, taking it up and keeping it with clean hands; or, having bathed and perfumed it with incense, reads it or recites it, keeps it or holds it, writes it or has it written, or recollects it, and does not engage in sinful deeds, then, to protect this sūtra, we will serve that person and we will guard them. Even when that person lies down to sleep, we will be present before them and will not let ill omens arise. Moreover, we will keep them from being harmed by vicious enemies and vicious seizing spirits (grahas). We will also guard the house in which they live. If they go on a journey, we will always follow behind them and provide whatever they need. Whichever of the four directions they go to, there will be no obstacles; they will continually meet with virtuous teachings; and when they die we will have them reborn among the gods. By that cause and that condition, we will see to it that they see the buddhas and do not forsake the Great Vehicle."

When they had said this, the Blessed One said to the bodhisattva mahāsattvas, to the gods, to the lords of the asuras and the rest: "It is so, it is so; it is as you have said. If one never even hears this sūtra, how could one ever see it? If anyone wishes to take up and hold this sūtra, keep it, read it or recite it, let them bathe until clean and put on clean clothes. In a clean and secluded room adorned with banners, victory banners and parasols, let them make offerings with various incenses, sandalwood, powders and unguents, and bow down. Then, beginning in this way during the six periods of the day and night, let them read this sūtra every day for seven days and nights, with mind undistracted, mindfulness undistracted, thought undistracted, intention undistracted, retention undistracted, conduct undistracted, and teaching and training undistracted. If, during the six periods of the day and night, they are able to bow to the buddhas and bodhisattvas named in this sūtra and to the twelve divisions of the scriptures, and to read or recite it with devotion and respect, then, just as this sūtra declares, all their grave misdeeds will be purified. Do not doubt this or be of two minds about it. Why? Because this sūtra of the Great Liberation That Extends in All Directions is the practice that the buddhas of the ten directions practice. It guards and protects; it is the mother of all the buddhas. It is the king of all sūtras. It is the essence of the

ultimate. It is the path of the bodhisattvas.

"This profound sūtra of the Great Liberation That Extends in All Directions is like the six great things in the world: it is inconceivable. What are the six? The great earth, the great waters, the great fire, the great wind, the great sun and great space. This sūtra is like the great earth: it bears everything, clean and unclean, good and bad. This sūtra is like the great waters: it washes away all filth. This sūtra is like the great fire: it burns up all the afflictions, impurities and defilements. This sūtra is like the great wind: it blows away all filth. This sūtra is like the great sun: it illuminates all darkness whatsoever. This sūtra is like space: it has room for all things whatsoever, good and bad. So vast is this Great Vehicle sūtra of the Great Liberation That Extends in All Directions that nothing compares with it: from the bodhisattvas above, through the śrāvakas in the middle, down to all who have bodies of the perishable aggregates below, there is no one for whom it has no room.

"Therefore retain this sūtra and keep it! Spread it everywhere! Have faith in it and respect it! You bodhisattva mahāsattvas should come to realize the wisdom of a buddha and directly see the self of a buddha. You gods too, if you take up and keep this sūtra, will continually see me, and you will see all the buddhas yet to come, turn the wheel of Dharma, and enter the great maṇḍala."

When he had said this, from among the great assembly the bodhisattva called Faith in Characteristics rose from his seat within the gathered assembly, draped his upper robe over one shoulder, bowed his head at the feet of the Blessed One, and said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, we have something to request and to ask. For the benefit and happiness of immeasurable beings, we pray that the Blessed One will grant us the opportunity and explain."

Then the Blessed One said to the bodhisattva Faith in Characteristics: "Very good, very good! Son of noble family, if you have questions, ask whatever you wish, and I will explain to you in detail."

"Your question, too, will bring benefit and happiness to immeasurable sentient beings."

Then the bodhisattva Faith in Characteristics said this to the Blessed One: "I remember that long ago in the past I heard it said that whoever hears even once the name of the Tathāgata called Ratnaśikhin will attain rebirth as a god. Not long after that, in the realm of King Sureśvaraprabha, the water of a great pond in a wilderness dried up, and ten thousand great fish that lived there,

scorched by the sun, were close to death. One called Jalavāhana saw those fish, and great loving-kindness and compassion for those beings arose in him. Even if he gave them water and food, they might survive only a few days; wishing them a long life free of hindrance, he recited the name of the Blessed One Ratnaśikhin three times. The moment those fish heard it, they died and were reborn as gods in the Heaven of the Thirty-Three. So it is told. Now, Blessed One, for the sake of this assembly and of the beings of future times, please teach the names of the buddhas, and please explain them so that, by hearing the name of the Blessed One Śākyamuni, beings beyond measure and beyond count may find help and happiness, merit beyond measure, perpetual abundance of wealth, and may also directly realize the very nature of a buddha. I pray that you explain them so that sentient beings who have broken the root vows and are deluded by mental afflictions may be completely liberated."

Then the Blessed One said this to the bodhisattva, the great being, Faith in Characteristics: "Son of noble family, if I were to explain at length the names of the buddhas of the ten directions, I could not finish even if I spoke for a hundred thousand times ten thousand eons. For although every drop of all the waters can be counted and known, the names of all the buddhas cannot be known by number. Although every Mount Meru can be weighed and reckoned by measures of weight, the names of all the buddhas cannot be known by number. Although the boundaries of space and its farthest end can be known, the names of all the buddhas cannot be known by number. I will teach you just a brief summary of the names of the buddhas of the three times. Whoever hears them even once with his ears will, as soon as he passes from this life, be reborn in the abode of the gods. And if, having heard them, one has devotion and respect, writes them down, recites them name by name and bows to them, all the misdeeds of saṃsāra accumulated over countless eons will be purified, and one will obtain immeasurable merit. When that person's time runs out, he will be born in whichever world system of the ten directions he has faith in. He will see me, and in the future he will also see the buddhas of the Fortunate Eon."

Then the Blessed One again spoke to the great assembly: "Arrange your robes properly, keep your body undistracted, your mind undistracted, your mindfulness undistracted and your thoughts undistracted, and if you wish to hear the Dharma, gather your mind one-pointedly.

Homage to the Blessed One Lamp King of Meru.
Homage to the Blessed One Ratnarāja.
Homage to the Blessed One Ratnaśikhin.
Homage to the Blessed One Amitāyus.
Homage to the Blessed One Vipaśyin.
Homage to the Blessed One Prabhūtaratna.
Homage to the Blessed One Śākyamuni.
Homage to the Blessed One Who Gathers and Holds All Dharmas.
Homage to the one beyond all words and measure.
Homage to the one without equal.
Homage to the boundless Dharma.
Homage to the one hard to fathom by thought.
Homage to the power of powers, abiding in power.
Homage to the fearless one of the ten powers.
Homage to the lord of the three worlds.
Homage to the great Teacher who guides all.
Homage to the one who cuts every bond.
Homage to the one who has reached the far shore.
Homage to the one who has gone beyond all worlds.
Homage to the one wholly free of the stream of saṃsāra.
Homage to the one liberated in meditative absorption.
Homage to the one who, like space, has no object of reference.
Homage to the king of Dharma among the many.
Homage to the one who conquers the hosts of the four māras.
Homage to the one of great loving-kindness, like a father toward his only son.

In life after life, wherever I die and pass on, wherever I appear and am born, may I always see the face of the Buddha, fully realize the very nature of a buddha, and reach the great nirvāṇa. Why is that? Because all who possess the perishable aggregates have the nature of a buddha.

O great assembly, join the palms of your ten fingers, listen properly, and make offerings from the depths of your hearts.

Listen as I proclaim the names
Of the buddhas of the ten directions and three times.
Even those with the five acts of immediate retribution
Will be brought to give rise to the mark of liberation.
To persons who lack roots of virtue,
Though I set them free and explain,

Even so they cannot understand:
For them the words, which are seeds, by nature fall hollow.
Only the wise and steadfast will remain.
Once the lesser vehicle is cleared away,
There will be the great vehicle alone;
Once the two vehicles are cleared away,
There will be the one vehicle alone.
Persons who lack roots of virtue
Will not come to hear this sound;
Only through having honored countless buddhas
Does one at last hear the names of the buddhas.
Those who take them up and hold them
Are liberated at least in part,
And dwell in happiness on the pure ground.
Now, too, within this Dharma of mine,
If, practicing all that the buddhas practiced,
One bows to the names of the buddhas
And takes up, reads and keeps this sūtra,
One will be freed from the works of Māra.
The misdeeds of the four root downfalls, the acts of immediate retribution
And wrong conduct will all be purified.
In time to come that person
Will surely accomplish the noble path as well.
Whoever does not give rise to faith
Will surely fall into the three lower realms.
If faith arises and one bows with diligence,
One will see buddhas beyond measure.
Therefore, bowing one-pointedly,
I aspire that measureless misdeeds be purified;
Therefore I bow with reverence."

Then the great assembly joined their palms, listened properly, gathered body and mind one-pointedly, and without laxity or wavering touched the five limbs of their bodies to the ground and listened from the depths of their hearts.

Then the Blessed One proclaimed and declared the names of the buddhas: "Homage to the immeasurable buddhas of the past.

Homage to the twenty thousand buddhas named Candrasūryapradīpa.
Homage to the thirty thousand buddhas named Dīpaṃkara.
Homage to the buddha Supreme Unobstructed Wisdom.
Homage to the buddhas who were the sixteen princes.
Homage to the buddha King of Space.
Homage to the buddha Prabhūtaratna.
Homage to the buddha Lamp King, Lord of Clouds.
Homage to the buddha King of Majestic Sound.
Homage to the buddha Amitābha.
Homage to the buddha Virtuous Thought.
Homage to the buddha Emanation Body.
Homage to the buddha Glory of Sun and Moon Radiance.
Homage to the buddha Wisdom of the Pure Lotus, King of Constellations.
Homage to the buddha King Adorned with Purity.
Homage to the buddha King Noble Nāga.
Homage to the buddha King of Cloud Thunder.
Homage to the buddha Holy Wisdom of the King of Constellations of Cloud Thunder.
Homage to the buddha Ratnarāja.
Homage to the buddha King of Śāla Trees.
Homage to the buddha Supreme Jewel, King of Glorious Splendor.
Homage to the buddha King of Shining Light.
Homage to the ten million buddhas named Unwavering Light.
Homage to the buddha Far-Reaching Light.
Homage to the buddha Moonlight.
Homage to the buddha Sandalwood Fragrance.
Homage to the buddha King Excellent Mountain.
Homage to the buddha Meru Crowned with a Divine Topknot.
Homage to the buddha Meru of Even Light.
Homage to the buddha Moon Form.
Homage to the buddha Right Mindfulness.
Homage to the buddha Stainless.
Homage to the buddha Unattached.
Homage to the buddha God of the Nāgas.
Homage to the buddha Unwavering Ground.
Homage to the buddha Supreme Flower.
Homage to the buddha Supreme Beryl Flower.
Homage to the buddha Color of Beryl and Gold.

Homage to the buddha Golden Treasury.
Homage to the buddha Lineage of the Earth.
Homage to the buddha Image of the Moon.
Homage to the buddha Melody of the Sun.
Homage to the buddha Lotus of Liberation.
Homage to the buddha Adorned with Rays of Light.
Homage to the buddha Clear Knowledge, Ocean of Intellect.
Homage to the buddha Water Light.
Homage to the buddha Great Melody.
Homage to the buddha Free of Stain and Illusion.
Homage to the buddha Who Has Abandoned Sorrow of Mind.
Homage to the buddha Blazing Jewel.
Homage to the buddha Sublime Crown.
Homage to the buddha Established in Heroism.
Homage to the buddha Holder of Wisdom and Good Qualities.
Homage to the buddha Who Outshines Sun and Moon.
Homage to the buddha Beryl Light of Sun and Moon.
Homage to the buddha Unsurpassed Beryl Light.
Homage to the buddha Most Supreme Lord.
Homage to the buddha Flower of Awakening.
Homage to the buddha Bright Moon.
Homage to the buddha Sunlight.
Homage to the buddha King of Flower Colors.
Homage to the buddha Light of the Moon in Water.
Homage to the buddha Dispeller of the Darkness of Doubt.
Homage to the buddha Deliverer from Suffering.
Homage to the buddha Devotion and Clear Faith.
Homage to the buddha Excellent of Old.
Homage to the buddha Splendor of Miraculous Power.
Homage to the buddha Wisdom of the Dharma.
Homage to the buddha Sound of Laughter.
Homage to the buddha Lion's Roar.
Homage to the buddha Voice of the Nāgas.
Homage to the buddha Abode of the World.
Homage to the buddha Sovereign Lord.
Homage to the buddha Amitāyus.
Homage to the buddha Amitābha.

Homage to the buddha Infinite Light.
Homage to the buddha Unobstructed Light.
Homage to the buddha Incomparable Light.
Homage to the buddha King of Blazing Light.
Homage to the buddha Blazing Light.
Homage to the buddha Root of Blazing.
Homage to the buddha Pure Light.
Homage to the buddha Light of Utmost Joy.
Homage to the buddha Light of Wisdom.
Homage to the buddha Unceasing Light.
Homage to the buddha Inconceivable Light.
Homage to the buddha Inexpressible Light.
Homage to the buddha Light Surpassing Sun and Moon.
Homage to the buddha Excellent Marks the Color of Refined Gold.
Homage to the buddha Far-Reaching Discernment.
Homage to the buddha Treasury of Jewels.
Homage to the buddha Immeasurable Melody.
Homage to the buddha Taste of Sweet Dew.
Homage to the buddha Victor of the Nāgas.
Homage to the buddha Power of the Victor.
Homage to the buddha Lion's Melody.
Homage to the buddha Stainless Light.
Homage to the buddha Supreme Glory.
Homage to the buddha Mañjuśrī Mountain.
Homage to the buddha Vajra King.
Homage to the buddha Unsurpassed Flower.
Homage to the buddha King of Fearless Power.
Homage to the buddha Sovereign Lord of Nāgas.
Homage to the buddha King of Lion's Splendor.
Homage to the buddha Sovereign King.
Homage to the buddha Pervading Light.
Homage to the buddha All-Illuminating.
Homage to the buddha All-Pure.
Homage to the buddha Fragrance of Tamāla Leaf and Sandalwood.
Homage to the buddha Light of Sandalwood Fragrance.
Homage to the buddha Jewel Banner.
Homage to the buddha Essence of Joy in the Heap of Jewels.

Homage to the buddha Unsurpassed Great Diligence.
Homage to the buddha Lamp Light of the Jewel Banner.
Homage to the buddha Shining Lamp of Wisdom.
Homage to the buddha Shining Glorious Light of the Ocean.
Homage to the buddha Vajra Firmness.
Homage to the buddha All-Pervading Golden Light.
Homage to the buddha Great and Mighty Diligence.
Homage to the buddha Heroic Valor.
Homage to the buddha Light of Compassion.
Homage to the buddha King of the Power of Compassion.
Homage to the buddha King of the Essence of Loving-Kindness.
Homage to the buddha King Arrayed in a Sandalwood Grotto.
Homage to the buddha Excellent and Good Lord.
Homage to the buddha Well Awakened.
Homage to the buddha King of Arrays.
Homage to the buddha Jewel Parasol of the Golden Mountain.

Homage to the buddha Sign of the Blazing Light of Golden Flowers.
Homage to the buddha Shining Light of the Great Lamp.
Homage to the buddha King, Sovereign of the Power of the Jewel Canopy Examined as Emptiness.
Homage to the buddha Light of Golden Flowers.
Homage to the buddha Light of the Jewel Flowers of Space.
Homage to the buddha King Arrayed in Beryl.
Homage to the buddha Light That Manifests Bodies Everywhere.
Homage to the buddha Changeless Light of Wisdom.
Homage to the buddha Who Subdues the Kings of the Māras.
Homage to the buddha Thousandfold Shining Light.
Homage to the buddha Victor of the Wisdom of Loving-Kindness.
Homage to the buddha Clear Light of Loving-Kindness.
Homage to the buddha Light That Purifies the World.
Homage to the buddha Melody of the Moon of Virtuous Solitude.
Homage to the buddha Supreme and Noble King of Wisdom.
Homage to the buddha Abiding as King of the Jewel Parasol.
Homage to the buddha King, Lord of Wisdom, Unsurpassed in the Nāga Lineage.
Homage to the buddha Light of Sun and Moon.

Homage to the buddha Jewel Light of Sun and Moon.
Homage to the buddha King Supremely Adorned with the Banner of Wisdom.
Homage to the buddha King of the Stainless Treasury.
Homage to the buddha Sign of Shining Light.
Homage to the buddha Shining Light of Blazing Gold.
Homage to the buddha Treasury of Shining Golden Light.
Homage to the buddha King, Sovereign of the Power of the Lion's Roar.
Homage to the buddha King of Supreme and Sublime Melody.
Homage to the buddha Banner of Constant Light.
Homage to the buddha King, Lamp That Discerns the World.
Homage to the buddha Who Has Attained the Royal Robe of Wisdom.
Homage to the buddha King of the Sublime Characteristics of the Dharma.
Homage to the buddha Light of Meru.
Homage to the buddha Light of the Sumanā Flower.
Homage to the buddha Light of the Utpala Flower.
Homage to the buddha King of Sublime Mighty Power.
Homage to the buddha King of the Power of Wisdom.
Homage to the buddha Light of Utmost Joy, Free of Turmoil.
Homage to the buddha King of Immeasurable Sound and Melody.
Homage to the buddha Light of Intelligence.
Homage to the buddha Light of the Golden Ocean.
Homage to the buddha King, Sovereign of the Mountain and Ocean of Wisdom.
Homage to the buddha Light of Great Liberation.
Homage to the buddha King Ever Filled with All Dharmas.
Homage to the buddha Who Shows No Folly.
Homage to all the emanation bodies of the buddhas of the past.

If one bows to one buddha of the past, to ten buddhas, a hundred buddhas, a thousand buddhas, ten thousand buddhas, all the terrible misdeeds committed in saṃsāra throughout countless, immeasurable eons will be purified.

With reverence I bow to a hundred thousand buddhas, to a million, ten million, a hundred million, a billion, and to buddhas countless and immeasurable, koṭis of niyutas as many as the sands of the Ganges.

If any person hears the names of the countless, immeasurable buddhas of the past, for eight hundred thousand eons he will not fall into the sufferings of the beings in hell. Therefore I bow with reverence.

Whoever, hearing the names of the buddhas of the past,
Bows to them with reverence
Attains the very nature of mind, and his misdeeds are purified.
The ten nonvirtues and the five acts of immediate retribution
He is able to vow never to commit again.
He will always hear the sublime Dharma
And possess the moral discipline of the Great Vehicle.
Therefore, in this way, I bow.
Excepted are only two kinds:
Those who revile the Dharma of the Great Vehicle,
And those who hold to the side of wrong conduct.
One whose very mind is completely pure
Is not to be called a wrongdoer;
He will always see immeasurable buddhas.
The four root misdeeds
And the five acts of immediate retribution, whatever one has done,
If one is able to regret them with a pure mind,
That is abiding as one should.
And because one bows with reverence,
The karma of the ten nonvirtues is purified,
And the moral discipline of the Great Vehicle is obtained.
Therefore I bow with reverence.

When those names of the buddhas of the past were proclaimed, ten thousand bodhisattvas attained acceptance of the unborn nature of phenomena. Eight hundred śrāvakas gave rise to at least a measure of the mind of the Great Vehicle. Five thousand monks became arhats. A hundred thousand gods and humans attained the pure Dharma eye.

Homage to the countless, immeasurable buddhas who dwell at present.
Homage to the million buddhas named Prasenajit.
Homage to the buddha Stainless Powder of Refined Gold.
Homage to the buddha Immeasurable Radiance.
Homage to the buddha King of Shining Light, Disk of the Sun.
Homage to the buddha Heap of Fragrance.
Homage to the buddha Hundred-Thousandfold Lion Form.
Homage to the buddha Lion at Play.
Homage to the buddha King, Mountain of All-Pervading Light of Good Qualities.
Homage to the buddha Jewel King, Blissful Abode of Good Qualities.

Homage to the buddha King Adorned with Jewel Flowers.
Homage to the buddha Austerity.
Homage to the buddha Sign of Meru.
Homage to the buddha Who Has Attained the King of Mountains.
Homage to the buddha Ratnaśrī.
Homage to the buddha Jewel Moon.
Homage to the buddha Blazing Jewel.
Homage to the buddha Jewel Ornament.
Homage to the buddha Lion's Roar of Austerity.
Homage to the buddha King of Great Light.
Homage to the buddha Changeless.
Homage to the buddha Bhaiṣajyarāja.
Homage to the buddha Fully Adorned.
Homage to the buddha Who Has Reached the Pavilion.
Homage to the buddha Moon Parasol.
Homage to the buddha Pervading Light.
Homage to the buddha Ratnarāja.
Homage to the buddha Vipaśyin.
Homage to the buddha Śikhin.
Homage to the buddha Viśvabhū.
Homage to the buddha Dispeller of Wrong Faith.

Homage to the buddha Kanakamuni.
Homage to the buddha Kāśyapa.
Homage to the buddha King of Thunder.
Homage to the buddha Essence of Dharma.
Homage to the buddha Sandalwood Flower.
Homage to the buddha Sandalwood Leaf.
Homage to the buddha Supreme Mind.
Homage to the buddha Incomparable Sage.
Homage to the buddha Drum of Sweet Dew.
Homage to the buddha Vipaśyin.
Homage to the buddha Shining Light of Sun and Moon.
Homage to the buddha Invincible Light.
Homage to the buddha King Endowed with Adornment.
Homage to the buddha King of Good Qualities, Whose Rays of Light Pervade Everywhere.

Homage to the buddha King of the Lion's Roar That Conquers the Four Māras.
Homage to the buddha Fearless Vajra.
Homage to the buddha Beryl Light.
Homage to the buddha King of Meru.
Homage to the buddha King of Pure Rays of Light.
Homage to the buddha Glory of Virtue.
Homage to the buddha Immeasurable Rays of Light.
Homage to the buddha Play of Dhāraṇī.
Homage to the buddha King of the Power of the Samādhi of Heroic Progress.
Homage to the buddha King, Sovereign of the Samādhi of Seeing Virtue.
Homage to the buddha Unsurpassed Good Qualities.
Homage to the buddha Sovereign of Miraculous Power.
Homage to the buddha Without Form as a Sign.
Homage to the buddha Scattered Form.
Homage to the buddha Without Sign of Smell.
Homage to the buddha Without Sign of Taste.
Homage to the buddha Without Sign of Touch.
Homage to the buddha Sovereign of Samādhi.
Homage to the buddha Sovereign of the Samādhi of Wisdom.
Homage to the buddha Sovereign of Jewel Form.
Homage to the buddha All-Gathering.
Homage to the buddha All-Radiant Glory of Kindness.
Homage to the buddha Śikhin.
Homage to the buddha Viśvabhū.
Homage to the buddha Dispeller of Wrong Faith.
Homage to the buddha Kanakamuni.
Homage to the buddha Kāśyapa.
Homage to the buddha Mind Delighting in Sweet Sound.
Homage to the buddha Utmost Joy.
Homage to the buddha Akṣobhya.
Homage to the buddha Sign of Meru.
Homage to the buddha Lion's Melody.
Homage to the buddha Sign of the Lion.
Homage to the buddha Lord of Clouds.
Homage to the buddha Ever Peaceful.
Homage to the buddha Sign of Indra.
Homage to the buddha Infinite Radiance.

Homage to the buddha Sign of Brahmā.
Homage to the buddha Who Has Passed Beyond All the Sufferings of the World.
Homage to the buddha Fragrance of Tamāla Leaf and Sandalwood.
Homage to the buddha Form of Meru.
Homage to the buddha King, Lord of Clouds.
Homage to the buddha Who Has Destroyed All the Fears of the World.
Homage to the ten million emanation bodies, the buddhas Śākyamuni.

If one bows with reverence to one buddha who dwells at present, to ten buddhas, a hundred buddhas, a thousand buddhas, ten thousand buddhas, all the heavy misdeeds of saṃsāra from countless eons will be purified.

Homage to a hundred thousand buddhas, to a million, ten million, a hundred million, a billion, and to buddhas countless and immeasurable, koṭis of niyutas as many as the sands of the river Ganges.

If anyone hears the names of the countless, immeasurable buddhas who dwell at present, for six hundred thousand eons he will not fall among the beings in hell. Therefore I bow with reverence.

If one bows to the buddhas
Now dwelling in the ten directions,
One is fully freed from all bad karma,
And even the misdeeds of the five acts of immediate retribution are purified.
One will always dwell on the pure ground,
Will dwell in happiness within the Dharma of the Śākya as well,
And in the end will be free of the three lower realms.
One will see the buddha Maitreya,
And will also see the thousand buddhas.
Therefore I now bow.
One will also see the buddhas of the ten directions,
Will always be born in pure fields,
Will hear the sublime Dharma,
And will fully realize that the Buddha is permanent.

When the names of the buddhas who dwell at present were proclaimed, bodhisattvas as many as the sands of two Ganges rivers entered the doors of dhāraṇī. Four million two hundred thousand gods and humans gave rise to the mind set on unsurpassed awakening.

Homage to the immeasurable buddhas of the Fortunate Eon who are yet to come.
Homage to the buddha Maitreya.
Homage to the buddha Pure Body.
Homage to the buddha Flower Light.
Homage to the buddha Perfect Flower.
Homage to the buddha Shining Light.
Homage to the buddha Name and Sign.
Homage to the buddha Light of Jambūnada Gold.
Homage to the buddha Radiance of Dharma.
Homage to the buddha Jewel Radiance.
Homage to the buddha Pervading Radiance.
Homage to the buddha All-Encompassing Sign.
Homage to the buddha All-Encompassing Light.
Homage to the buddha Mountain and Ocean of Wisdom.
Homage to the buddha King, Sovereign of Miraculous Power.
Homage to the buddha Array of Jewels.
Homage to the buddha Sublime Person.
Homage to the ten million buddhas named King Who Has Attained Sovereignty.
Homage to the buddha Characteristic of Jewels.
Homage to the buddha Delightful to Behold.
Homage to the twenty thousand buddhas named King Adorned with Signs of Light.
Homage to the thirty thousand buddhas of the same name, All-Glorious.
Homage to the buddha King of Thunder.
Homage to the forty-eight thousand buddhas named Changeless Light.
Homage to the buddha Jewel Moon King.
Homage to the buddha Stainless Light.
Homage to the buddha Sublime Form.
Homage to the buddha Rays of Light of Sublime Form.
Homage to the buddha Who Has Destroyed All the Hosts of Obstructors.
Homage to the buddha Mass of Fragrance.
Homage to the buddha Mass of Sound.
Homage to the eighty thousand buddhas named Array of Rays of Light.
Homage to the eight million buddhas named Array of Rays of Light.
Homage to the buddha Adorned with Jewel Flowers.

Homage to the buddha King of Supreme Good Qualities.
Homage to the buddha Shining Light of Refined Gold.
Homage to the five hundred buddhas named Lotus Light, who received prophecy.
Homage to the buddha Fearless Nārāyaṇa.
Homage to the buddha Adorned with Excellent Flowers.
Homage to the buddha Sovereign of the Vajra Samādhi.

If one bows to one buddha yet to come, to ten buddhas, a hundred buddhas, a thousand buddhas, ten thousand buddhas, the heavy misdeeds of saṃsāra from countless, immeasurable eons will be purified.

If any person comes to hear the names of buddhas immeasurable and countless, a hundred thousand, a million, ten million, a hundred million, a billion, koṭis of niyutas as many as the sands of the Ganges, for four hundred thousand eons he will not fall among the beings in hell. Therefore I now bow.

Whoever bows with reverence
To the buddhas yet to come,
Excepting only those of wrong conduct,
Will have purified those misdeeds:
The three obscurations and the five acts of immediate retribution.
He will dwell in happiness in the Buddha's Dharma
And will see immeasurable buddhas.
He will always hear the sublime Dharma as well.
Therefore I now bow with reverence.
Whoever bows to the buddhas
Of the ten directions and the three times
Will have the faults of past,
Future and present,
And the ten bad actions he has done,
Purified here and now, before his eyes.
In time to come he will also see
The very essence of the Buddha.
Therefore have devotion toward them.
If one recites, asks about, reads and bows,
In life after life, wherever one appears and is born,
Wrong views will not arise.
One will constantly attain liberation,
Will never be born in border lands,

Will not be born in evil places either,
And will not meet with cruel kings.
For four billion eons
One will not be born among the beings in hell.
Therefore, if one bows with reverence,
The karma of the ten nonvirtues is purified,
And one will fully attain the great dhāraṇī.

When the Blessed One proclaimed the names of the buddhas yet to come, fifty thousand bodhisattvas came to abide on the ground of irreversibility. Seven hundred nuns became arhats. Six million two hundred thousand gods and humans attained the pure Dharma eye.

Homage to the great dhāraṇīs and the twelve divisions of the sūtras.
Homage to the division of discourses.
Homage to the division of prophecies.
Homage to the division of verses.
Homage to the division of discourses in song.
Homage to the division of inspired utterances.
Homage to the division of introductory accounts.
Homage to the division of narratives of deeds.
Homage to the division of accounts of the past.
Homage to the division of birth stories.
Homage to the division of extensive teachings.
Homage to the division of marvels.
Homage to the division of established instructions.
Homage to all the scriptural collections of the Great Vehicle.

Whoever hears the names of the twelve divisions of the sūtras and of the perfections, and praises them, bows to them, recites them, gives rise to devotion toward them, takes them up or keeps them, that person will not fall among the beings in hell for two hundred thousand eons, and will possess the wisdom that remembers former and later lives. Therefore bow with reverence!

When the Blessed One proclaimed the names of the twelve divisions of the sūtras, eighty-five thousand bodhisattvas attained the vajra samādhi. A million śrāvakas gave rise to the mind of the Great Vehicle. Ten thousand monks and nuns attained the fruit of arhatship. Immeasurable gods and humans attained the pure Dharma eye.

Homage to all the bodhisattvas, the great beings, of the ten directions.
Homage to the bodhisattva Mañjuśrī, the Youthful.
Homage to the bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara.
Homage to the bodhisattva Mahāsthāmaprāpta.
Homage to the bodhisattva Ever Diligent.
Homage to the bodhisattva Never Ceasing.
Homage to the bodhisattva Ratnapāṇi.
Homage to the bodhisattva Bhaiṣajyarāja.
Homage to the bodhisattva Heroic Effort.
Homage to the bodhisattva Ratnacandra.
Homage to the bodhisattva Moonlight.
Homage to the bodhisattva Full Moon.
Homage to the bodhisattva Great Power.
Homage to the bodhisattva Immeasurable Power.
Homage to the bodhisattva Exalted in the Three Realms.
Homage to the bodhisattva Bhadrapāla.
Homage to the bodhisattva Maitreya.
Homage to the bodhisattva Ratnakūṭa.
Homage to the bodhisattva Guide.
Homage to the bodhisattva Śrīgarbha.
Homage to the bodhisattva Delighting in Teaching.
Homage to the bodhisattva Nāga Tree.
Homage to the bodhisattva Jewel Sandalwood Flower.
Homage to the bodhisattva Superior Conduct.
Homage to the bodhisattva Infinite Conduct.
Homage to the bodhisattva Well-Arrayed Conduct.
Homage to the bodhisattva Pure Conduct.
Homage to the bodhisattva Dhāraṇī Holder.
Homage to the bodhisattva Vajra Nārāyaṇa.
Homage to the bodhisattva Ever Respectful.
Homage to the bodhisattva Flower of the Former King.
Homage to the bodhisattva Delightful to See.
Homage to the bodhisattva Sublime Melody.
Homage to the bodhisattva Power of Diligence and Good Qualities.
Homage to the bodhisattva Akṣayamati.
Homage to the bodhisattva Vimalagarbha.
Homage to the bodhisattva Vimalanetra.
Homage to the bodhisattva Samantabhadra.

Homage to the bodhisattva Mañjuśrī.
Homage to the bodhisattva Maitreya.
Homage to the bodhisattva Good Thought.
Homage to the bodhisattva Never Empty.
Homage to the bodhisattva Flower of Miraculous Power.
Homage to the bodhisattva Clear Light.
Homage to the bodhisattva Clear Light of Wisdom.
Homage to the bodhisattva Supreme Wisdom.
Homage to the bodhisattva Jñānaketu.
Homage to the bodhisattva Peaceful Faculties.

Homage to the bodhisattva Aspiration of Wisdom.
Homage to the bodhisattva Fragrant Image.
Homage to the bodhisattva Jewel Radiance.
Homage to the bodhisattva Abiding in the Center.
Homage to the bodhisattva Conduct of Cessation.
Homage to the bodhisattva Liberation.
Homage to the bodhisattva Dharmagarbha.
Homage to the bodhisattva Contemplating Equality.
Homage to the bodhisattva Not Conceiving Equality.
Homage to the bodhisattva Contemplating the Equal and the Unequal.
Homage to the bodhisattva King Lord of Samādhi.
Homage to the bodhisattva King Lord of the Dharma.
Homage to the bodhisattva Characteristic of the Dharma.
Homage to the bodhisattva Sign of Light.
Homage to the bodhisattva Adorned with Light.
Homage to the bodhisattva Great Ornament.
Homage to the bodhisattva Ratnakūṭa.
Homage to the bodhisattva Heap of Intelligence.
Homage to the bodhisattva Ratnapāṇi.
Homage to the bodhisattva Ratnamudrāhasta.
Homage to the bodhisattva Nityotkṣiptahasta.
Homage to the bodhisattva Nityapralambahasta.
Homage to the bodhisattva Ever Loving.
Homage to the bodhisattva Lord of Joy.
Homage to the bodhisattva King of Joy.
Homage to the bodhisattva Melody of Intelligence.

Homage to the bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha.
Homage to the bodhisattva Holder of the Jewel Lamp.
Homage to the bodhisattva Jewel Hero.
Homage to the bodhisattva Jewel Gaze.
Homage to the bodhisattva Net of Truth.
Homage to the bodhisattva Net of Light.
Homage to the bodhisattva Faultless Thought.
Homage to the bodhisattva Prajñākūṭa.
Homage to the bodhisattva Ratnaśikhin.
Homage to the bodhisattva King of the Gods.
Homage to the bodhisattva Vanquisher of Māra.
Homage to the bodhisattva Glory of Lightning.
Homage to the bodhisattva Īśvararāja.
Homage to the bodhisattva Adorned with the Marks of Good Qualities.
Homage to the bodhisattva Siṃhanāda.
Homage to the bodhisattva Thunder.
Homage to the bodhisattva Sound That Releases, Seizes, and Shakes the Mountains.
Homage to the bodhisattva Gandhahastin.
Homage to the bodhisattva White Gandhahastin.
Homage to the bodhisattva Sublime Birth.
Homage to the bodhisattva Flower Ornament.
Homage to the bodhisattva Brahmā's Net.
Homage to the bodhisattva Jewel Staff.
Homage to the bodhisattva Invincible Sound.
Homage to the bodhisattva Ornament of the Field.
Homage to the bodhisattva Golden Crest.
Homage to the bodhisattva Jewel Crest.
Homage to the bodhisattva Light of Adorned Youth.
Homage to the bodhisattva World Holder.
Homage to the bodhisattva Dawning Light.
Homage to the bodhisattva Hard to Conquer.
Homage to the bodhisattva Virtuous Qualities.
Homage to the bodhisattva Flower Light.
Homage to the bodhisattva Jewel Sandalwood Flower.
Homage to the bodhisattva Secret of the Dharma.
Homage to the bodhisattva Lord of the Dharma.

Homage to the bodhisattva Chief of Glory.
Homage to the bodhisattva Unblinking.
Homage to the bodhisattva Crown of Glory.
Homage to the bodhisattva Former Virtue.
Homage to the bodhisattva Root of Virtue.
Homage to the bodhisattva Supreme Host.
Homage to the bodhisattva Holy Being.
Homage to the bodhisattva Siṃha.
Homage to the bodhisattva Siṃhaghoṣa.
Homage to the bodhisattva Pure Knowledge.
Homage to the bodhisattva Excellent Nārāyaṇa.
Homage to the bodhisattva Virtuous Mind.
Homage to the bodhisattva Direct Seeing.
Homage to the bodhisattva All-Protecting.
Homage to the bodhisattva Lightning Light.
Homage to the bodhisattva Priyadarśana.
Homage to the bodhisattva Sign of Illumination.
Homage to the bodhisattva Sublime Mind.
Homage to the bodhisattva Akṣayamati.
Homage to the bodhisattva Profound Wisdom.
Homage to the bodhisattva Sign of Peace.
Homage to the bodhisattva Unobstructed.
Homage to the bodhisattva Supreme in Virtue.
Homage to the bodhisattva Field of Merit.
Homage to the bodhisattva Lotus Ornament.
Homage to the bodhisattva Guṇagarbha.
Homage to the bodhisattva Candrottara.
Homage to the bodhisattva Ratnamudrāhasta.
Homage to the bodhisattva King of the Jewel Crown.
Homage to the bodhisattva Devoted to Truth.
Homage to the bodhisattva Seeing Wisdom.
Homage to the bodhisattva Attained King.
Homage to the bodhisattva Profound King.
Homage to the bodhisattva Flower King.
Homage to the bodhisattva Sublime Form.
Homage to the bodhisattva Skilled in Questioning.
Homage to the bodhisattva Skilled in Answering.

Homage to the bodhisattva Directly Realizing Characteristics.
Homage to the bodhisattva Sign of Certainty.
Homage to the bodhisattva Certain Heap.
Homage to the bodhisattva Born of Joy.
Homage to the bodhisattva Abiding in Bliss.
Homage to the bodhisattva Terror of Māra.
Homage to the bodhisattva Giver of Wisdom.
Homage to the bodhisattva Giver of Refuge.
Homage to the bodhisattva Exalted Rank of Wisdom.
Homage to the bodhisattva Hero of Generosity.

Homage to the bodhisattva Focus of Wisdom.
Homage to the bodhisattva Aspiration of Wisdom.
Homage to the bodhisattva Four Means of Gathering.
Homage to the bodhisattva Revealer of Melody.
Homage to the bodhisattva Supreme Ocean.
Homage to the bodhisattva Delight in the Dharma.
Homage to the bodhisattva Path of Awakening.
Homage to the bodhisattva Sūtra Holder.
Homage to the bodhisattva King of Loving-Kindness.
Homage to the bodhisattva Maheśvara.
Homage to the bodhisattva Brahmaghoṣa.
Homage to the bodhisattva Sublime Color.
Homage to the bodhisattva Sandalwood Grove.
Homage to the bodhisattva Siṃhaghoṣa.
Homage to the bodhisattva Supreme Sound.
Homage to the bodhisattva Form of Sublime Color.
Homage to the bodhisattva Adorned in Various Ways.
Homage to the bodhisattva Banner of the Śākyas.
Homage to the bodhisattva Born from the Crown.
Homage to the bodhisattva King of Illumination.
Homage to the bodhisattva Great Light.
Homage to the bodhisattva Fearless.
Homage to the bodhisattva Heap of Secrets.
Homage to the bodhisattva Shining Flower.
Homage to the bodhisattva Supreme Chief.
Homage to the bodhisattva Manifesting Bodies Everywhere.

Homage to the bodhisattva Clear Knowing.
Homage to the bodhisattva Glorious Ocean.
Homage to the bodhisattva Infinite Body.
Homage to the bodhisattva Lord King of Medicine.
Homage to the bodhisattva Kāśyapa.
Homage to the bodhisattva King of the Stainless Treasury.
Homage to the bodhisattva Protector of All.
Homage to the bodhisattva Lofty and Noble Lord of Glory.
Homage to the bodhisattva Beryl Light.
Homage to the bodhisattva Fearless.
Homage to the bodhisattva Ocean King.
Homage to the bodhisattva Siṃhanāda.
Homage to the bodhisattva Faith in Characteristics.
Homage to the bodhisattva Earth Holder.
Homage to the bodhisattva Ornament of Light.
Homage to the bodhisattva Light Rays.
Homage to the bodhisattva Great Eloquence.
Homage to the bodhisattva Power of Loving-Kindness.
Homage to the bodhisattva Great Compassion.
Homage to the bodhisattva King of Support.
Homage to the bodhisattva Power of Support.
Homage to the bodhisattva Glory of Support.
Homage to the bodhisattva Benefiting All.
Homage to the bodhisattva Upholding All.
Homage to the bodhisattva Unchanging Light.
Homage to the bodhisattva Universal Light.
Homage to the bodhisattva True Light.
Homage to the bodhisattva Dispeller of Wrong Faith.
Homage to the bodhisattva Light of the Gods.
Homage to the bodhisattva Jewel King.
Homage to the bodhisattva Suffused with Light.
Homage to the bodhisattva Preceptor Who Teaches.
Homage to the bodhisattva Great Patience.
Homage to the bodhisattva King of Flowers.
Homage to the bodhisattva Heap of Flowers.
Homage to the bodhisattva Light of Wisdom.
Homage to the bodhisattva Ocean of Wisdom.

Homage to the bodhisattva Steadfast Mind.
Homage to the bodhisattva Śākya Clan.
Homage to the bodhisattva Golden Light.
Homage to the bodhisattva Golden Essence.
Homage to the bodhisattva Ever Compassionate.
Homage to the bodhisattva Supreme Dharma.
Homage to the bodhisattva Treasure of Wealth.
Homage to the bodhisattva Mountain Light.
Homage to the bodhisattva Mountain of Wisdom.
Homage to the bodhisattva Great Illumination.
Homage to the bodhisattva Holder of All.
Homage to the bodhisattva Mighty Mountain.
Homage to the bodhisattva Mountain Peak.
Homage to the bodhisattva Mountain Banner.
Homage to the bodhisattva King of Mountains.
Homage to the bodhisattva Tamer of Māra.
Homage to the bodhisattva Thunder.
Homage to the bodhisattva King of Rain.
Homage to the bodhisattva King of Thunder.
Homage to the bodhisattva Precious Wheel.
Homage to the bodhisattva Shining Jewel.
Homage to the bodhisattva Chief Jewel.
Homage to the bodhisattva Jewel Treasury.
Homage to the bodhisattva Jewel Illumination.
Homage to the bodhisattva Unchanging Jewel.
Homage to the bodhisattva Jewel Seal.
Homage to the bodhisattva Jewel Maṇḍala.
Homage to the bodhisattva Jewel Ornament.
Homage to the bodhisattva Jewel Water.
Homage to the bodhisattva Jewel Light.
Homage to the bodhisattva Blazing Jewel.
Homage to the bodhisattva Jewel Revealer.
Homage to the bodhisattva Jewel Maker.
Homage to the bodhisattva Devoted to the Dharma.
Homage to the bodhisattva Pure King.
Homage to the bodhisattva Sign of the Crown.
Homage to the bodhisattva Golden Radiance.

Homage to the bodhisattva Jewel Topknot.
Homage to the bodhisattva Thousand Lights.
Homage to the bodhisattva Lightness.
Homage to the bodhisattva Intelligent Awareness.
Homage to the bodhisattva Understanding the Moon.
Homage to the bodhisattva Candraprabha.
Homage to the bodhisattva Wheel of the Dharma.
Homage to the bodhisattva Pure Light.
Homage to the bodhisattva Examiner of Giving.
Homage to the bodhisattva Universal Glory.

Homage to the bodhisattva Pervading Light.
Homage to the bodhisattva Sublime Banner.
Homage to the bodhisattva Gentle Melody.
Homage to the bodhisattva Blazing Glory.
Homage to the bodhisattva Light of Signs.
Homage to the bodhisattva Ocean Moon.
Homage to the bodhisattva Essence of the Ocean.
Homage to the bodhisattva Sublime Moon.
Homage to the bodhisattva Pure Wisdom.
Homage to the bodhisattva Exalted Light.
Homage to the bodhisattva Glory of the Moon.
Homage to the bodhisattva Sunlight.
Homage to the bodhisattva Vajra.
Homage to the bodhisattva Blazing Banner.
Homage to the bodhisattva Noble Glory.
Homage to the bodhisattva Clear Ocean.
Homage to the bodhisattva Vast Ocean.
Homage to the bodhisattva Discerning Objects.
Homage to the bodhisattva Clear Wisdom.
Homage to the bodhisattva Good Qualities.
Homage to the bodhisattva Liberating Light.
Homage to the bodhisattva Revealer of Secrets.
Homage to the bodhisattva Generous Giver.
Homage to the bodhisattva Power of Form.
Homage to the bodhisattva Thorough Tamer.
Homage to the bodhisattva Hidden Body.

Homage to one, ten, a hundred, a thousand, and ten thousand bodhisattvas.

If one pays homage to one million, two million, three million, four million, five million, six million, seven million, eight million, nine million, and ten million bodhisattvas, the heavy negative deeds of saṃsāra accumulated over as many as countless eons will be purified.

If one pays homage to one hundred thousand bodhisattva great beings, to one million, ten million, one hundred million, and one billion, and to ten thousand times ten thousand hundred thousands of them, all the inexhaustible negative deeds of saṃsāra accumulated over as many as countless eons will be purified.

Homage to bodhisattva great beings as numerous as the sands of one Ganges River.
Homage to as many as the sands of two Ganges Rivers.
Homage to as many as the sands of three Ganges Rivers.
Homage to as many as the sands of four Ganges Rivers.
Homage to as many as the sands of five Ganges Rivers.
Homage to as many as the sands of six Ganges Rivers.
Homage to as many as the sands of seven Ganges Rivers.
Homage to as many as the sands of eight Ganges Rivers.
Homage to as many as the sands of nine Ganges Rivers.
Homage to as many as the sands of ten Ganges Rivers.
Homage to as many as the sands of a hundred Ganges Rivers.
Homage to as many as the sands of a thousand Ganges Rivers.
Homage to as many as the sands of ten thousand Ganges Rivers.
Homage to as many as the sands of many hundreds of thousands of koṭis of niyutas of Ganges Rivers.

If one pays homage to them, all the heavy negative deeds of saṃsāra accumulated over as many as countless, immeasurable eons will be completely purified.

Whoever hears these names of the bodhisattva great beings will not fall into the sufferings of the hells for forty thousand eons. They will not belong to the realm of the three existences, but will always belong to the realm of liberation. They will not be born in a borderland, nor in an evil land; they will not take an inferior body, and will not hold wrong views. They will not be born into a low family, nor born among the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas). Their faculties and limbs

will be complete. They will always hear the sublime Dharma. Even without having taken the moral discipline of the vows, they will always be endowed with moral discipline. They will have the beautiful conduct of the Great Vehicle, and they will also see the very nature of the buddhas. Therefore, paying homage with reverence, they will abide truly in the Dharma of the buddhas, and in a later life they will attain the accomplishment of buddhahood.

When the names of those bodhisattva great beings were proclaimed, eight million eight hundred thousand faithful sons and daughters of noble family attained the fruit of non-returner. Nine million four hundred thousand gods attained the fruit of once-returner. Seven million eight hundred thousand monks who had lost their minds regained the very nature of their minds and attained the fruit of arhatship. One million bodhisattvas attained the great dhāraṇī, and in the future they will attain perfect awakening.

Then the Blessed One said to the bodhisattva great being Faith in Characteristics, "Son of noble family, you yourself have said that if beings tormented by suffering hear but once the name of the past buddha, the Blessed One called Ratnaśikhin, they will be reborn as gods when they die and pass on. You have also requested me to proclaim the names of all the buddhas, wishing all beings to be free from suffering and to be delivered from the world. For that reason, I too shall fully proclaim the names of the Three Jewels to you and to all people. Yet ultimately there is a single Jewel, and it is taught as three by way of guiding beings. Suppose someone hears their names and keeps them in mind from the depths of the heart, and at the time of death some spiritual friend has that person deliberately utter the names of the Three Jewels three times, saying namo buddhāya namo dharmāya namaḥ saṃghāya. When that person dies and passes on, they will not go to the three lower realms, but will be born in whichever of the world realms of the ten directions they have faith in. They will gradually serve all the buddhas and will see all the bodhisattvas. They will also hear the Dharma of the Great Vehicle, the Great Liberation Extending in All Directions, taught by Mañjuśrī and Samantabhadra, and immediately upon hearing it they will attain acceptance of the nonarising of phenomena. Son of noble family, that person, too, hears the names of the Three Jewels at last only because of having thoroughly accumulated roots of virtue over countless eons."

Then the bodhisattva Faith in Characteristics said this to the Blessed One:

"Blessed One, in what way are they called the Three Jewels? Are they to be considered one entity, two entities, or three entities? If they are one entity, they amount to a single refuge. If they are three entities, they become three refuges; and if they become three refuges, then the Buddha and the Dharma will be different in their very sphere, and so too will the Saṅgha. If they are three separate refuges, people will see them in three ways, and even if they practice the Dharma for three eons, they will not come to understand them as a single vehicle. Blessed One, for the benefit and happiness of beings, please explain this to me. Having heard it, I wish to explain it, with its distinctions clearly drawn, to all people. After the Blessed One has passed into nirvāṇa, whoever hears these names will also attain the state of unsurpassed awakening."

When he had made this request, the Blessed One gave his approval to the bodhisattva Faith in Characteristics, saying "Excellent!" and continued: "Son of noble family, excellent, excellent! That you are able to ask me about so great a matter as this is most excellent indeed, excellent! Son of noble family, one who asks about so great a matter as this does not dwell on the first ground, the second ground, the third ground, the fourth ground, the fifth ground, the sixth ground, the seventh ground, or the eighth ground. It is the great being who dwells on the tenth ground, the Cloud of Dharma, who asks the Tathāgata about so great a matter as this. Listen well! I shall explain it with its distinctions clearly drawn.

"Son of noble family, all people, obscured by ignorance since beginningless time, circle in the prison of the three realms, tormented by all kinds of suffering. Wandering back and forth among the six paths of existence, with no refuge and no place of support, they turn to gods and demons in search of refuge. Non-Buddhists bind their own hands and feet and give up their lives; yet though they seek refuge, there is no liberation from suffering. Though they leap into fire or into lakes and give up their lives, there will never come a time of liberation from saṃsāra.

"For this reason the Tathāgata, the great protector, through the samādhi of loving-kindness, regarded with tender love the people who are continually deluded. In order to teach the names of the Three Jewels and make them a true support and abode, to the beginners in the training, the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, he taught the Three Jewels as distinct entities, like the rungs of a ladder. Afterward, to the holy beings who had long practiced pure conduct, he also taught the true and ultimate Three Jewels as a single entity,

teaching that within the one Buddha Jewel the Dharma Jewel and the Saṅgha Jewel are also present.

"Son of noble family, if one asks why they are called jewels: just as the seven kinds of precious things of the world sustain the lives of the destitute, so too the Three Jewels in the world are called jewels because they give birth to the dharma body of people and cause their wisdom to increase.

"As for the Three Jewels as distinct entities: the one of whom it is said that he manifested a body in Rājagṛha, practiced ascetic observances and austerities as though he were a bodhisattva in order to deliver beings, and, having attained perfect awakening at the foot of the tree of awakening, accomplished the benefit of himself and others, is called the Buddha. Buddha means one who has woken from the sleep of ignorance.

"The Saṅgha is a field for offerings. It is called the Saṅgha because the disciples gain the meaning from the Teacher. The Saṅgha is of two kinds: the harmonious and the unconditioned. As for attaining the unconditioned: being liberated, through true emptiness, into emptiness, the very characteristic of wisdom, is the unconditioned. The exhaustion of the defilements that arise unceasingly from delusion is also called the unconditioned. Having brought all defilements to cessation, being in harmony with the noble ones in a single abode, without dispute, is harmony. Whatever possesses these two meanings is called the Saṅgha.

"Son of noble family, the Dharma is all phenomena, virtuous and nonvirtuous, conditioned and unconditioned. Nonvirtuous phenomena are to be abandoned; virtuous phenomena are to be increased. Moreover, whatever is apprehended by the mind is called the Dharma Jewel. Therefore the Buddha and the Saṅgha are not one entity, and their essential natures are also different. The Dharma is of one sphere with the Saṅgha and the Buddha, and it is difficult to distinguish them separately.

"If one asks how they are difficult to distinguish: suppose one were to apply the names Buddha and Saṅgha as mere designations, and call the aggregate of liberation attained through discernment, together with all virtuous qualities, the Dharma Jewel. The matter is not like that either. Why is that? It is through the power of virtuous qualities and merit that a human body is obtained. Without the Dharma there is no person, and apart from persons, how could there be anything called the Dharma Jewel? What is being discussed here today is that persons and the Dharma are in accord as one, and yet are also

distinct: through the power of the Dharma one is established as a person, and the Dharma proceeds under the power of persons. Therefore the aggregate of liberation, the ten powers, the four fearlessnesses, the thirty-two major marks, the eighty excellent minor marks, the perfections and so on, and countless samādhis as well, are taught as the Buddha Jewel. The aggregate of liberation of the śrāvakas is taught as the Saṅgha Jewel. The enumerations of these qualities as conditioned and unconditioned phenomena, and the practice of observing them through reasoning, are called the Dharma Jewel.

"From the very beginning there is a single sphere. Although it is explained as two meanings, within the dharmadhātu there is also the distinction between the Buddha and the Saṅgha, and these too are included within the Dharma Jewel. When they have been explained in these three ways and are made the refuge and support of beings, beings will be freed from the terrors of cycling through the three realms. Yet although they are freed from the gross suffering of all their conduct, subtle suffering is not exhausted. For this reason I shall explain the true and ultimate Three Jewels.

"Suppose it is said that, in the earlier explanation, the Buddha has suffering, the Dharma is impermanent, and the Saṅgha too is impermanent, and that since they are suffering they are not a true support. What is explained here today, however, abides permanently. That which practitioners of yoga directly realize as the nature of reality, emptiness, free from the eight distortions, without arising or ceasing, and which has become the true support and abode: that is called the Buddha Jewel.

"Whatever is found of the permanent Dharma, practiced until the object of focus is brought to its culmination, is called the true Dharma Jewel. When practitioners comprehend the nature of reality of the true Dharma and become established in the state that is permanently unconditioned, that is called the Saṅgha. Moreover, being free forever of the eight distortions, so that the noble ones and all people are in harmony and there is never any dispute at all, is called the Saṅgha Jewel.

"Previously the Three Jewels were explained as distinct, in terms of persons and the Dharma. Here today, within the single entity of the Buddha, the Dharma and the Saṅgha also arise. For this reason I have explained to you the Three Jewels as a single entity. All people should be turned toward the single vehicle."

Then the bodhisattva Faith in Characteristics said this to the Blessed One: "Buddha, Blessed One, what should one contemplate in order to accomplish the Great Vehicle?"

The Blessed One said, "Son of noble family, one accomplishes the Great Vehicle by reflecting that the three realms are impermanent."

The bodhisattva Faith in Characteristics asked, "How should one contemplate impermanence?"

He said, "When one contemplates impermanence, one should abandon the afflictions, make true mindfulness manifest, and put loving-kindness and compassion first. One who teaches the Dharma to people and delivers them, yet hopes for nothing in return, is called a bodhisattva. In this way one should accomplish the Great Vehicle without ever abandoning beings.

"Son of noble family, suppose there were a great city, one yojana in circumference, with many gates. On the road leading there are precipices, pitch darkness, and a great many terrifying places; yet whoever reaches that city becomes supremely happy. A certain man had an only son whom he loved dearly. But hearing that in that city there were immeasurable riches of happiness, he left his beloved son behind, and wishing to go to that city, by all kinds of means he crossed the frightening stretches of the road and arrived at the city gate. He set one foot inside, and before he had lifted the other foot, he remembered his son and thought, 'I have an only son. Why did I not take him with me when I set out? Who will look after him now that I am gone?' Thinking this, he gave up the city and set off back toward his son.

"Son of noble family, the loving-kindness and compassion of a bodhisattva are just like that. Out of love and compassion they cultivate the five superknowledges. Yet even when, having cultivated them, their defilements are exhausted, they act as though they did not know it and do not take up that attainment. Why is that? Out of compassion for beings they give up the exhaustion of defilements and the superknowledges and go to the level of ordinary beings.

"Son of noble family, in the simile, the city called happy stands for the great liberation. The many gates stand for the eighty-four thousand gates of samādhi. The great frightening places on the road stand for such things as Māra and the obstructing spirits. Reaching the city gate stands for attaining the five superknowledges. Lifting one foot and setting it inside the threshold stands for wisdom. The foot not yet lifted stands for the others whom the

bodhisattva has not yet liberated. The words 'an only son is left behind' stand for the beings of the five paths of existence. Remembering the son stands for great compassion. Turning back toward the son stands for taming beings and leading them to attain liberation. Not taking up reward or attainment stands for skillful means.

"Son of noble family, that the bodhisattva great beings, held by great love and great compassion, never abandon beings is inconceivable.

"Furthermore, son of noble family, from the time the bodhisattva, the holy being, first gives rise to the mind of awakening until reaching the heart of awakening, he should always impart the ten virtues to beings. What are the ten? Not taking life, not taking what is not given, not engaging in sexual misconduct out of desire, not speaking falsehood, not slandering or causing division, not speaking harsh words, not speaking meaningless idle chatter, not being covetous, not being malicious, and not holding wrong views. When a bodhisattva in this way practices loving-kindness and compassion to perfection, through loving-kindness he teaches virtue and establishes beings in happiness, and through compassion he frees them from suffering and delivers them from the hells. When a bodhisattva sees people who wish to accomplish nirvāṇa but do not know the gateway, he should cultivate a mind of compassion toward them. By the power of compassion he opens the gateway of nirvāṇa for all beings, reveals the abode of bliss, and leads them to attain the fruit of the Great Vehicle. This is called practicing the conduct of the bodhisattva great beings."

Then the bodhisattva Faith in Characteristics said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, what is it that is called true mindfulness?"

He said, "It is the practice of the Dharma that neither arises nor ceases."

He asked, "Blessed One, what is the nonarising of phenomena, and what is their nonceasing?"

He said, "Son of noble family, nonvirtuous phenomena should be made not to arise, and virtuous phenomena should be made not to cease. One who practices such conduct throughout the three realms will not be stained by the defilement of the habitual tendencies of the five kinds of sense pleasure.

Son of noble family, if you wish to travel through the three realms and deliver sentient beings, you should travel through the three realms by means of these ten qualities. Although, in conventional words and following the letters, the

three realms are said to exist, unsurpassed awakening does not abide in the three times; and since perfected awakening does not fall into any category, what need is there to speak of the three times and the three realms?

What are the ten qualities? They are: to have no swelling or shrinking of the mind at praise and blame; not to discriminate in the mind on hearing what is pleasant or unpleasant; to give rise to compassion equally for the wise and the deluded; to regard sentient beings with equality, whether high or low; not to divide the mind in two over offerings made with respect or without respect; not to mock the faults and failings of others; though seeing many different vehicles, to regard them as a single vehicle; even on hearing the sounds of the three lower realms, not to give rise to fear or terror; to regard bodhisattvas as being like the tathāgatas; and, when a buddha appears in the time of a degenerate eon, to give rise to the perception that this is wondrous and marvelous. These are the ten. If they possess these ten qualities, bodhisattvas will not be afflicted by the habitual tendencies of the afflictions.

When bodhisattvas, holy beings, travel through the three realms, if they take great compassion as their basis, then even though their light mingles with that defiled field, they do not become one with its dust. Therefore they are called difficult to fathom.

Whoever, in a pure world,
For the span of a single eon
Strictly guards moral discipline,
Is surpassed by the one who for a mere instant
Practices loving-kindness: that one is holy and supreme.
Whoever here in this world
Has done evil with body, speech, and mind,
And is certain to fall into the three lower realms,
Is purified at once by that mind of loving-kindness.
Should any bodhisattva
Be born into an evil world,
Let them not give rise to fear or misgiving.
Though they have misdeeds that would cast them into the lower realms,
They are purified by no more than a headache.
Whoever wishes to cut their bonds,
Or wishes to abandon the obscurations of the afflictions,
Even if born into this evil world,
Increases in wisdom by guarding the true Dharma.

Than to practice pure moral discipline
For a hundred thousand eons in a pure field,
It is easier to dwell in this world
Just from today until tomorrow.
Why is that?
When I behold the two worlds,
The world of Akṣobhya and the world of Sukhāvatī,
Utterly pure, there is
Not even the name of suffering.
In those realms I do not consider
The making of merit to be hard.
Whoever, in these worlds,
Bears for themselves what is hard to bear
And also leads others to patience,
That is the holy and supreme merit.
Therefore, bodhisattvas,
When you travel through this evil world,
Do not be afflicted or grieve,
But guide all sentient beings.
If you give rise to a mind of steadfast diligence,
You will swiftly attain unsurpassed awakening.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Ākāśagarbha, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, we have come here today to ask about the causes and conditions of the awakening of bodhisattvas. If the Tathāgata grants me the opportunity, I shall summon my courage and ask."

The Blessed One said, "Excellent! Son of noble family, in the past you generated roots of virtue under many hundreds of thousands of buddhas. You are skilled in practicing the means of bodhisattvas, and for the sake of all bodhisattvas you have steadfast diligence in the conduct of awakening. Ask well, whatever you wish. I shall explain it to you in detail."

The Blessed One having granted him the opportunity, Ākāśagarbha said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, what must a bodhisattva do so that the mind is not tormented by observances and austerities? What must a bodhisattva do so as to have no regret concerning definitive words? What must a bodhisattva do so that the roots of virtue increase? What must a bodhisattva do so as to be without fear and unwavering in conduct? What must a bodhisattva do so that

the true Dharma is brought to completion? What must a bodhisattva do so as to understand well everything from the first ground to the tenth? What must a bodhisattva do to become supremely skilled in means? What must a bodhisattva do to become a teacher of sentient beings? What must a bodhisattva do so as not to waste the awakening mind, life after life? What must a bodhisattva do so that the workings of the mind do not stray from the one into many different kinds? What must a bodhisattva do to accomplish well through the jewel of the Dharma? What must a bodhisattva do to come forth free of the faults prohibited by moral discipline and the Vinaya? What must a bodhisattva do so that the afflictions cease? What must a bodhisattva do to be in harmony with all the many assemblies? What must a bodhisattva do to open well the door of the gift of the Dharma? What must a bodhisattva do so as not to lose the roots of virtue, by the force of former power? What must a bodhisattva do to practice the six perfections naturally, without depending on the instruction of others? What must a bodhisattva do to set aside meditative concentration and meditative absorption and be born in the desire realm? What must a bodhisattva do so as not to turn back from the qualities of a buddha? What must a bodhisattva do so that the roots of virtue increase, so as to travel through the three realms and act as a teacher to sentient beings, and so that the essential nature of the Buddha is not interrupted?"

Then the Blessed One gave his approval to the bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha, saying "Excellent," and said: "That you are able to ask the Tathāgata about the activities of bodhisattvas is most excellent, excellent indeed. Listen well, and keep mindfulness present."

He replied, "Blessed One, as you command, I long to hear; I wish to listen and to take it to heart."

The Blessed One said to the bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha: "Son of noble family, a bodhisattva who possesses four qualities will not be tormented in mind by observances and austerities.

What are the four qualities? They are: to give rise to great compassion for all sentient beings; to give rise to diligence and not be lazy; to know the cycle of birth and death to be like a mere dream; and to contemplate the wisdom of the buddhas with a true mind. These are the four. A bodhisattva who possesses these four qualities will have no torment of mind from austerities and observances.

Further, a bodhisattva who possesses four qualities will not come to regret definitive words midway. What are the four? They are: to declare in definitive words that one has directly realized phenomena to be selfless; to declare in definitive words that it is not fitting to conceive a longing for any state of rebirth whatsoever; to speak constantly in praise of the Great Vehicle with definitive words; and to declare with definitive words that the results of virtuous and evil actions are not lost. These are the four.

Further, a bodhisattva who possesses four qualities will increase the roots of virtue. What are the four? They are: guarding moral discipline, great learning, giving gifts, and going forth. These are the four.

Further, a bodhisattva who possesses four qualities will be without fear and will not waver from right conduct. What are the four? It is to remain unmoved even when overcome by loss of gain, by ill repute, by blame and reproach, and by suffering. These are the four.

Further, a bodhisattva who possesses four qualities will bring the pure white qualities to completion. What are the four? They are: to teach others to have conviction in virtuous and evil actions; to expect no return for giving; to guard and protect the true Dharma; and, with great wisdom, to act as a teacher to all bodhisattvas. These are the four.

Son of noble family, further, a bodhisattva who possesses four qualities will understand well everything from the first ground to the tenth. What are the four qualities? They are: to cultivate the roots of virtue over a long time; to clear away all faults and failings; to be supremely skilled in means; and to dedicate to awakening whatever virtuous diligence one has practiced. These are the four.

Further, a bodhisattva who possesses four qualities will become supremely skilled in means. What are the four? They are: to act in accord with the minds of sentient beings; to give rise to a mind that rejoices in the merit and good qualities of others; to confess with remorse whatever misdeeds one has; and to request all the tathāgatas to turn the wheel of the Dharma. These are the four.

Further, a bodhisattva who possesses four qualities will become a teacher of sentient beings. What are the four? They are: always to bring about the benefit and happiness of sentient beings; to give up entirely one's own pleasure; to be gentle and cultivate patience; and to abandon laziness. These are the four.

Further, a bodhisattva who possesses four qualities will not waste the awakening mind, life after life. What are the four? They are: always to keep in mind all the buddhas of the ten directions; to dedicate whatever merit one has made to unsurpassed awakening for the sake of sentient beings; to rely on spiritual friends; and to proclaim the Great Vehicle fully. These are the four.

Further, a bodhisattva who possesses four qualities will not let the workings of the mind stray from the one into many different kinds. What are the four? They are: to abandon the mind of the śrāvakas; to abandon the mind of the pratyekabuddhas; not to grow weary of practicing the Dharma; and to teach others whatever Dharma one has heard. These are the four.

Further, a bodhisattva who possesses four qualities will accomplish well the jewel of the Dharma. What are the four? They are: to perceive the Dharma of the Great Vehicle as like a jewel, because it is rare; to regard the Dharma of the Great Vehicle as like medicine, because it clears away all the illnesses of the mind; to regard the Dharma of the Great Vehicle as like a treasure of wealth, because it is never lost; and to regard the Dharma of the Great Vehicle as the cessation of suffering, because it brings one to nirvāṇa. These are the four.

Further, a bodhisattva who possesses four qualities will come forth free from broken moral discipline and from the faults of the afflictions. What are the four? They are: to attain patience with the nonarising of phenomena, because phenomena have no coming; to attain patience with the nonceasing of phenomena, because phenomena have no going; to attain patience with the dependent origination of phenomena, because one knows that phenomena arise from causes and conditions; and to attain the patience of nonabiding, because there is no separate mindstream. These are the four.

Further, a bodhisattva who possesses four qualities will bring the afflictions to cessation. What are the four? They are: to make true mindfulness present; to restrain the senses; to be able to develop the power of virtuous qualities; and to delight in solitary places and abandon busyness. These are the four.

Further, a bodhisattva who possesses four qualities will be in harmony with all the many assemblies. What are the four? They are: even when practicing the Dharma oneself, not to practice it in order to gain distinction; to be free of laziness and always give rise to a mind of honor and respect; to seek only the benefit of the Dharma and not be proud; and, even when teaching virtuous qualities to others, not to seek gain, honor, or fame. These are the four.

Further, a bodhisattva who possesses four qualities will open well the door of the gift of the Dharma. What are the four? They are: to guard and protect the true Dharma fully; to benefit one's own wisdom and teach others; always to practice noble conduct; and not to conceptualize phenomena as pure or impure. These are the four.

Further, a bodhisattva who possesses four qualities will not lose the roots of virtue, by the force of former power. What are the four? They are: not to take advantage of the faults and failings of others; always to cultivate loving-kindness toward those who are full of aversion; always to explain all phenomena as dependent origination; and always to keep unsurpassed awakening in mind. These are the four.

Further, a bodhisattva who possesses four qualities will practice the six perfections naturally, without depending on the instruction of others. What are the four? They are: always to give the gift of the Dharma to others; not to speak of the faults of others; to be skilled at teaching sentient beings, gathering them through the Dharma; and to understand the profound Dharma thoroughly. These are the four.

Further, a bodhisattva who possesses four qualities will set aside meditative concentration and meditative absorption and take birth visibly in the desire realm.

What are the four? They are: to make the mind gentle and pliant; to gain the power of the roots of virtue; not to abandon any sentient being; and to be able to cultivate continually the might of wisdom and skillful means. These are the four.

Further, a bodhisattva who possesses four qualities will not turn back from the qualities of a buddha. What are the four? They are: not to grow weary in mind even when experiencing countless cycles of birth and death; always to make offerings to countless buddhas; to cultivate immeasurable loving-kindness; and to give rise to devotion toward the immeasurable wisdom of the buddhas. These are the four.

Son of noble family, further, a bodhisattva who possesses four qualities will keep the very nature of the Buddha from being interrupted. What are the four? They are: not to give up one's aspiration for the sake of all sentient beings; to have faith in the practice of giving; to have zeal for great diligence; and continually to practice the qualities of a buddha with a profound mind. These are the four. When bodhisattvas, great beings, travel through the three realms

and practice these four kinds of conduct, benefiting sentient beings and bringing them happiness, and cultivate them so as to bring them beyond the world, the very nature of the Buddha will not be interrupted."

At that time, when the Dharma of the Great Vehicle had been explained in these sets of four, forty thousand gods gave rise to the mind set on unsurpassed awakening. Twenty-five thousand humans attained patience with the nonarising of phenomena. Forty-eight thousand bodhisattvas attained the perfection of patience with the dharmadhātu and fully realized the wisdom of the buddhas.

Then, on that occasion, the Blessed One said this to the bodhisattva, the great being Ākāśagarbha: "Son of noble family, take up this sūtra well! Keep it!"

When he had said this, the bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha said, "Blessed One, what is the name of this sūtra? How should it be kept?"

The Blessed One said: "Keep it under the name The Great Liberation Extending in All Directions, Which Conquers the Domain of Māra, Destroys the Non-Buddhists Together with Their Armies, Clears Away All Afflictions, Unties the Bonds of Wrong Views and of the Five Kinds of Sense Pleasure, Breaks Open the Prison of the Three Realms, Ferries Beings Across to Liberation from Saṃsāra and to Nirvāṇa, Moistens the Dried-Up Causes That Are the Holy Seeds, Sends Down the Dharma Rain of the Six Perfections, the Great Causes and Conditions, Makes the Sprouts and Flowers of the Beings of the Three Vehicles Grow and Flourish, and Brings About the Supreme Fruit of Awakening as the One Vehicle."

Then the bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, in the presence of countless buddhas of the past, in countless gatherings and in immeasurable assemblies, I have heard many kinds of teachings, many kinds of meanings, many kinds of signs, and many kinds of vehicles, yet I have never heard such a wondrous and marvelous Dharma as this, such wondrous and marvelous meaning, such wondrous and marvelous signs, or such a wondrous and marvelous Great Vehicle. What I have heard today, I shall now keep from being interrupted.

Blessed One, the Tathāgata is permanent, and the Dharma and the Saṅgha do not cease. Yet because the sentient beings of the three realms arise of themselves and cease of themselves, and do not see the Tathāgata and do not see the Dharma and the Saṅgha, it is said that these pass into nirvāṇa and cease. We, by the blessing of the Tathāgata, travel through the three realms

and follow along with ordinary beings, and it is only as a figure of speech that we say, 'He passes into nirvāṇa.'

Blessed One, after the Tathāgata has passed into nirvāṇa, we shall bring it about that, by means of the eighty thousand vehicles, the wisdom of the buddhas is realized and the Dharma body of the great being is attained. We shall spread this sūtra among the sentient beings who belong to the dharmadhātu. We shall hold it and keep it, read it, and recite it. Cultivating it just as it has been taught, we shall attain buddhahood all at one time. We shall not abandon it.

Blessed One, if any son or daughter of noble family, after the Blessed One has passed into nirvāṇa, in the degenerate age, commits this sūtra to memory and reads it, or recites it, or writes it out in a volume, or has it written out, how much merit will they obtain?"

The Blessed One said: "Son of noble family, greater by far than the merit of someone who fills a great trichiliocosm with precious jewels and gives them as a gift is the immeasurable merit of merely hearing the name of this sūtra. Greater by far than the merit of someone who fills ten thousand world systems with precious jewels and gives them as a gift is the immeasurable merit of merely keeping this sūtra made into a volume. Than someone who fills the world systems of the ten directions with precious jewels and gives them as a gift, greater by far, immeasurably, is the merit of one who writes, or has written, a single syllable, a single verse, or a single śloka of this sūtra of the Great Vehicle that extends in all directions. Even than filling countless world systems with jewels and giving them as a gift, if someone wholeheartedly reads or recites a single śloka of this sūtra, that merit is greater still, beyond measure. Even than granting the protection of life to all the sentient beings who fill a thousandfold world system, if someone wholeheartedly understands the meaning of a single word of this sūtra and teaches others the meaning of a single word or a single śloka, that merit is greater still, beyond measure.

Why is that? Material giving is the giving of the śrāvakas; it does no more than produce long life and wealth, and does not free one from saṃsāra. The Dharma giving of the Great Vehicle generates the roots of awakening in sentient beings and gathers in the life of wisdom of the three vehicles.

Son of noble family, those who read and keep this sūtra, even if they were formerly evil and wicked, now possess virtue. Even if they formerly suffered, they now possess wealth.

Even if they were formerly bound, they now possess release and liberation. Even if they had formerly not crossed over, they have now crossed over. Even if they were formerly fools, they have now become masters. Even if they were formerly subject to defilements, they are now free of defilement. Even if their conduct was formerly that of ordinary beings, they now possess the conduct of the noble ones. Even if they formerly opposed the path of the Dharma, they have now entered the noble path. Though their body is the body of an ordinary person, because they read and keep this sūtra, their understanding is like the wisdom of the noble ones. Even if they were formerly afflicted, now, because they read and keep this sūtra, they are ones who pass into nirvāṇa just like the buddhas, the blessed ones."

When the Blessed One had said this, the bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha said this: "Blessed One, according to what the Tathāgata has explained, it is said, 'Though formerly ordinary beings, they now possess the conduct of the noble ones,' and 'Even if formerly afflicted, now, by reading and keeping this sūtra, they are ones who pass into nirvāṇa just like the buddhas, the blessed ones.' If that is so, then do those who have broken moral discipline, who have committed the acts of immediate retribution, and who have disparaged the true Dharma also abandon the afflictions merely by reading this sūtra, and come into accord with nirvāṇa? Since that point is hard to understand, Blessed One, please explain it in detail."

The Blessed One said: "Excellent, excellent! Son of noble family, since you have asked well, I too shall explain well. Son of noble family, it is because all sentient beings do not see the Buddha that there are wrong views, broken moral discipline, and disparagement of the true Dharma. When the Buddha remains in the world, there is never any broken moral discipline or disparagement of the true Dharma.

How is that? Suppose, for example, that a certain elder had an only son whom he cherished and loved dearly. While the father was present, he instructed and trained him day and night, and so there was nothing amiss in anything the son did. The son, for his part, held his father in great respect, listened to his father's words, and never did wrong.

Then one day the father set out on a long journey, and stayed away a long time without returning. Meanwhile the son forgot his father's instructions and did many wrongs. Because the father had stayed away so long without returning, people said that the father had died, and the son wept and

gradually fell into corrupt ways. Overcome by grief, he lost his senses and forgot even what his father had taught him, and did nothing but what was contrary, much like those who disparage the Dharma.

When, after a long time, the father one day returned home, the son was filled with great joy and contentment. He remembered his father's former instructions, kept them in mind, and did no more wrong. Because he has seen his father and trusts that his father is not dead, he should not be called one who has wrongly fallen. Because he acts without contradicting his father's command, he should not be called a disparager either.

Son of noble family, 'the elder' is the Tathāgata. 'The only son' is all sentient beings. 'The father's instruction and training' is moral discipline. 'Set out on a long journey' is the Tathāgata's going to other realms to turn the wheel of the Dharma. 'Not seeing the father' is saying 'He has passed away.' 'Overcome by grief' is being veiled by the obscurations. 'Not keeping in mind' is broken moral discipline. Because they say he has died, there is the doing of evil. Because they confuse the meaning, there is disparagement. That the Tathāgata returns from other realms and is seen by sentient beings is the trust that the Buddha does not pass into nirvāṇa. That the Buddha teaches the Dharma and the nature of the mind is found again is moral discipline left unbroken. To trust that he does not pass into nirvāṇa is to be free of transgression. To act without contradicting the teaching and to know its meaning is not to disparage the Dharma.

Son of noble family, reading and keeping this sūtra purifies all the heavy evils of the afflictions of countless cycles of saṃsāra. Whoever hears this sūtra hears the name of the Buddha. Whoever sees this sūtra sees the face of the Buddha. Whoever holds this sūtra holds the body of the Buddha. Whoever practices this sūtra carries out the deeds of the Buddha. Whoever explains this sūtra explains the deeds of the Buddha. Whoever knows the meaning of this sūtra knows the meaning of the Buddha. Whoever carries out the deeds of the Buddha and unravels well the meaning of the Buddha will become utterly free of afflictions. Why is that? Because this sūtra has come into their hands, the afflictions will be completely abandoned.

Son of noble family, count eighty thousand eons as a single day, thirty such days as a month, and twelve such months as a year. When a hundred thousand koṭis of niyutas of eons reckoned in this way have passed, one meets with the appearance of a single buddha. Again, after an equal number

of eons have passed, one meets with the appearance of a single buddha. Yet far rarer even than that is meeting with this sūtra. To meet with this sūtra is like meeting with all the buddhas of the ten directions and the three times.

Therefore, if the intelligent take up this sūtra, keep it, read it, recite it, write it out, have it written out, and also teach it to others, their wrong views, the afflictions of ignorance, and their defiled evil deeds will be completely purified. They will abide as a field of merit. They will also become worthy to receive the immeasurable offerings of the world."

When the Blessed One had said this, Ākāśagarbha said, "Blessed One, if it is said that not even pratyekabuddhas are worthy to receive the offerings of the world, how could ordinary beings be worthy to receive offerings?"

The Blessed One said: "It is impossible that pratyekabuddhas should not be worthy to receive offerings. Even though they cannot teach the Dharma to sentient beings and deliver them, because they enter meditative concentration and meditative absorption, they rise from absorption, display great miraculous emanations, and deliver sentient beings; therefore they are worthy to receive offerings."

Then the bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha said this to the Blessed One:

"Blessed One, it appears in certain sūtras that one may not even live together in the same land with those of wrong view and broken moral discipline, nor even bathe in the same river with them; and it appears that at the poṣadha such a person has lost the noble path and is not included within the Saṅgha. Why then is it said here today that even those of broken moral discipline become worthy to receive offerings? If they become worthy to receive offerings, then they are no different from the Tathāgata, and are like the noble arhats and the pratyekabuddhas. Blessed One, I pray that you explain just this much in detail. When I have heard it, I too shall teach it in the same way to sentient beings. I shall set them free."

The Blessed One said to the bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha: "Excellent, excellent! Son of noble family, that you and the others here today, endowed with perfect loving-kindness and compassion and thinking with tenderness of sentient beings, ask about this point is most excellent. I shall explain it in detail; reflect on it well and listen. The sphere of this Dharma discourse is not understood even by the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, and it is not within the range of thought of Māra, the non-Buddhists, or ordinary beings. It is known only to the Buddha and understood by you.

Son of noble family, I have always taught those who have given rise to the mind set on awakening, explaining that if they give without discriminating between good and bad sentient beings, the accumulation of merit will be brought to completion. By giving to an animal one gains the good qualities of merit. By giving to one of wrong conduct one gains the good qualities of merit a thousand times over. Son of noble family, those whose roots of virtue have been cut off, on dying and passing on, go into the line of those of wrong conduct. Those who are ungrateful and shameless go into the line of animals. If even those who are the ripened result of wrong conduct can receive the offerings of the meritorious, what need is there to speak of persons who read and keep this sūtra? Therefore the power and blessing of the Great Vehicle sūtra the Great Liberation Extending in All Directions are inconceivable. Because it completely purifies broken moral discipline, the course of the acts of immediate retribution, disparagement of the true Dharma, wrong views, and the evil deeds of the afflicted, such persons are able to receive offerings."

The bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, the Sugata is inconceivable. The power and blessing of the Great Liberation Extending in All Directions are inconceivable. And the good qualities of the person who holds and reads this sūtra are inconceivable."

The Blessed One said: "So it is. Son of noble family, so it is. It is just as you have said: they will obtain inconceivable and limitless good qualities."

When this had been said, the Blessed One then spoke these words to the bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha: "I remember that in the past, in the eon called Utterly Pure, I made offerings to ninety-two koṭis of niyutas of buddhas and served them. Yet because I practiced in the manner of the śrāvakas, many faults arose, and there were immeasurable breaches of moral discipline; and so those tathāgatas did not give me a prophecy.

After that eon had passed, in the eon called Longing to See, I made offerings to forty koṭis of buddhas and served them; yet those buddhas did not give me a prophecy.

After that eon too had passed, in the eon called Brahmaghoṣa, I made offerings to twenty-two koṭis of buddhas and served them; yet those buddhas did not give me a prophecy.

After that eon too had passed, in the eon called Joyful Mind, I made offerings to eighty-four thousand buddhas and served them; yet those buddhas did not

give me a prophecy.

After that eon too had passed, in the eon called Refuge from Suffering, in the world called Fully Adorned, there appeared the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the Perfectly Awakened Buddha, Perfect in Knowledge and Conduct, the Sugata, Knower of the World, Unsurpassed Guide Who Tames Beings, Teacher of Gods and Humans, the Buddha, the Blessed One called Great Generosity. At that time I made offerings to forty koṭis of buddhas and served them, and only then did I hear the name of this sūtra. Although I completely abandoned the afflictions, I had still not seen this sūtra. At that time, on that occasion, I gathered inconceivable offering articles of every kind and made offerings, yet those tathāgatas did not give me a prophecy.

Son of noble family, in the past, through so many eons, I made so many offerings to so many buddhas, served them, and praised them. I abandoned the afflictions. I kept the śrāvaka vows and lived the holy life of perfect conduct. I gave gifts and trained in moral discipline. I abandoned pride, anger, and delusion. I practiced the qualities of ascetic purification, patience, and a mind of loving-kindness. I explained with diligence just as I had heard. I forgot nothing of all that I had heard. I abandoned busyness and dwelt in solitude. I entered meditative concentration and meditative absorption, and on emerging from concentration I listened to the Dharma, read it, recited it, reflected on it, and so on. Yet those victors did not give me a prophecy.

Why was that? Because all the vows I had taken were broken and many lapses occurred; because I was attached to the vehicles of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas; and because I had not heard this Great Vehicle sūtra, the Great Liberation Extending in All Directions. Therefore bodhisattvas, great beings, should abandon the conduct of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. If they cultivate the Great Vehicle sūtra the Great Liberation Extending in All Directions, they will obtain a prophecy.

Even if I were to recite the names of those buddhas from one eon to the next, I could not finish. Son of noble family, after those eons had passed, I saw the Tathāgata Unchanging Light teaching this Dharma discourse, the Great Vehicle sūtra the Great Liberation Extending in All Directions, to an immeasurable great assembly, and only then, at that time, did I first hear it and see it. Having received it from that Victor, I held it, read it, recited it, reflected on its meaning, and so on, and immediately I attained acceptance of the nonarising of phenomena. The Tathāgata Unchanging Light then gave me

a prophecy, saying, "In the future you will become the tathāgata, arhat, perfectly complete buddha called Śākyamuni." Therefore, son of noble family, if by taking up this Dharma discourse, keeping it, reading it, and so on, one will swiftly attain even buddhahood, what need is there to mention becoming worthy of the offerings of the world with its gods and humans?

Son of noble family, for this reason I shall speak verses in praise of the power of this Great Vehicle Dharma discourse, which is like a precious essence, which is inconceivable, and which gives discipline to those whose discipline is broken and precious jewels to the destitute:

The Great Vehicle, by comparison, is like the ocean;
The lesser vehicle is water in an ox's hoofprint.
The Great Vehicle, by comparison, is Mount Meru;
The lesser vehicle is an anthill.
The Great Vehicle, by comparison, is like the sun and moon;
The lesser vehicle is a mere spark.

This vehicle is the Great Vehicle,
The inconceivable vehicle.
Like space, for example,
It makes room for all sentient beings.
Among all the vehicles there are,
None goes beyond this vehicle.
From within this Great Vehicle
Vehicles of many kinds arise.
If it had a number that could be measured,
It could not carry all beings across.
This unsurpassed vehicle
Is able to carry all sentient beings across.
Whoever has practiced this immeasurable one,
The Great Vehicle that is like space, knows:
Just as space is immeasurable
And has no form or shape at all,
So too the Great Vehicle
Is unobstructed and immeasurable.
All sentient beings, every one of them,
May ride upon this Great Vehicle;
If one reflects upon the vehicle's nature,
Its capacity is vast and holds a multitude.

Were the good qualities of the Great Vehicle
And the practice of the single vehicle
Explained in full for immeasurable eons,
One still could not reach their end.
Among all the vehicles there are,
The Great Vehicle is the sacred and supreme.
If with firm resolve one takes up this Great Vehicle,
One goes straight to the foot of the tree of awakening.
This unsurpassed vehicle,
Free of bonds and free of obstruction,
Is supreme above the Lesser Vehicle,
And so one comes to sit at the seat of awakening.

Examining the twelve links of dependent origination,
Out of loving compassion for sentient beings,
To all sentient beings of the ten directions
One should teach the Great Vehicle sūtras.
The vehicle that is the Great Vehicle
Never increases or diminishes;
Since like space it holds everything,
The Great Vehicle is inconceivable.
Therefore all sentient beings
Should cultivate it with diligence,
And attain the superknowledges
And great wisdom.

If you wish to dispel the hosts of gods, the divine māras,
The non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), and the afflictions,
Go for refuge to the Great Vehicle
And come to possess the six superknowledges.
The three knowledges and the three liberations:
By these, Māra and the tīrthikas are vanquished.
Since they also crush wrong views,
The Great Vehicle is supremely needed.
Since all afflictions are destroyed
And the roots of virtue are brought to perfection,
The power of the Great Vehicle is inconceivable,
And so it is very hard to measure.
Worldly phenomena

And all phenomena beyond the world,
Those of the ones in training and those beyond training, all of them,
Are gathered together in the Great Vehicle.

Sentient beings who act in ways that lead to the lower realms
Hold wrong views and rely on evil friends.
Whoever has no faith in the Great Vehicle
Cannot vanquish the māras of affliction.
Abandoning these and going for refuge to the Great Vehicle,
Those who long for liberation train in the Great Vehicle.
Whatever person wishes to know the great meaning
Feels joy on hearing the Great Vehicle explained;
This shows that he is a person of the Great Vehicle.
A mind of calm abiding endowed with superknowledge
Is likewise adorned by the power of the Great Vehicle.
Whoever is able to practice the Great Vehicle
Does not cut off the lineage of the Three Jewels.
Whoever turns toward the Three Jewels
Obtains immeasurable merit.

Going to the world realms of the ten directions,
Making offerings to the immeasurable victors of the ten directions,
And likewise honoring the Great Vehicle sūtra Extending in All Directions:
If one does this, no vehicle in the world can rival it.
Endowed with glory and splendor, it vanquishes saṃsāra;
Therefore the Great Vehicle is hard to fathom.
One will obtain beauty of form, strength, and mastery,
And the perfect dharmakāya will be fully accomplished.
Whoever rides upon this Great Vehicle
Experiences unsurpassed joy.
If, through the giving of one's body, one cultivates compassion and love,
Thereby one will attain the unsurpassed vehicle.
Those who keep moral discipline, diligence, and pure conduct
Can even eclipse the sun and moon by manifest miraculous power;
That too is through the power of practicing the Great Vehicle.
One who, with one's own mind, practices diligence without interruption
Thereby attains the Great Vehicle.
Even if there are obscurations that oppress one with suffering,

By meditating on the Great Vehicle they are all purified.
Whoever dwells happily in the Dharma of the Great Vehicle
Has a life and enjoyments like those of a buddha.
One endowed with right mindfulness and diligence
Also gains the power of the four bases of miraculous power.
Relying on the true meaning of the sacred Dharma
Is also through the power of meditating on the Great Vehicle.
Possessing the fearlessnesses and the ten powers,
Being adorned with the thirty-two excellent major marks,
The vajra-like samādhi and all wisdom as well:
These are through the power of meditating on the Great Vehicle.

Son of noble family, whoever takes up this Great Vehicle Dharma discourse and keeps or reads even a single syllable, a single word, or a single verse of it will come to possess merit such as this. What is it? It is this:

Whoever holds this sūtra
Will be parted from all suffering.

They will never fall into the lower realms,
And will go to a state of happiness.
Whoever hears this sūtra
In the future, in the evil age,
That they will finally attain buddhahood
I too shall prophesy.
Whoever is always devoted to the Victor,
The Victor too is always devoted to them.
If one protects the Victor's Dharma,
The Victor too will protect that one.
One will attain great miraculous power
And be able to turn the wheel of the Dharma,
To free beings from the stream of saṃsāra,
And even to crush Māra together with his army.
From that Victor, Unchanging Light,
I heard this sūtra;
Abiding in acceptance, I received a prophecy,
And became the one called Śākyamuni.
After I have passed into nirvāṇa,
Whoever holds this sūtra,

That they will become fully and perfectly awakened
I too shall prophesy.
Whoever in the future time
Understands the meaning of this sūtra
And explains it fully to the foolish
Does not cut off the lineage of the Three Jewels.
Even when the Buddha no longer remains in the world,
Wherever in the world this sūtra
Abides, in those shrines
It is as though the Buddha were present in person.

Why is that? Because in the past I received this sūtra from immeasurable tathāgatas and kept it, and at the time of the destruction of the eon I explained it extensively to others; thus I obtained the thirty-two major marks as well.

So he spoke. Then the bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, all the tathāgatas have taught the thirty-two major marks of a great being. Now here too the Blessed One has spoken of the thirty-two major marks. Blessed One, please distinguish and teach by the power of which karmic causes each of them is accomplished."

The Blessed One said, "Son of noble family, the Tathāgata accomplishes the thirty-two major marks by accomplishing immeasurable good qualities. If I were to explain them extensively, the explanation would not be finished even in an eon, so now I shall explain to you just a summary. What are they? They are as follows.

By wholeheartedly guarding pure moral discipline and by being steadfast in one's commitments, one comes to possess the mark of feet that are well planted. By welcoming and escorting one's teachers, by listening to the Dharma, and by taking great care in building temples and stūpas, one comes to possess the mark of wheels with a thousand spokes on the palms and soles. By not despising any sentient being, one comes to possess the mark of broad heels. By fully protecting the sacred Dharma, one comes to possess the mark of long fingers. By habitually practicing the four means of attracting disciples, one comes to possess the mark of hands and feet whose fingers and toes are joined by a web. By giving fine clothing, one comes to possess the mark of soft and tender hands and feet. By giving delicious, clean, and agreeable food and

drink, one comes to possess the mark of the seven prominent places being well raised. By delighting in hearing the Buddha's Dharma, one comes to possess the mark of calves like those of the eṇa antelope. By concealing and covering the deceit and faults of others, one comes to possess the mark of the private organ withdrawn into a sheath. By cultivating the ten virtues, one comes to possess the mark of an upper body like a lion's. By properly taking up virtuous dharmas and always teaching them to sentient beings, one comes to possess the mark of being very full between the shoulders. By acting as protector and refuge for those in fear, one comes to possess the mark of beautifully rounded shoulders. By delighting in helping others to build temples or stūpas, and by never saying to those who ask, "I have nothing," one comes to possess the mark of arms hanging straight down to reach the kneecaps. By always accomplishing all virtuous dharmas and by caring for the lives of others, one comes to possess the mark of a body that is large and straight. By giving medicines, care, and wholesome food to the sick, one comes to possess the mark of having obtained the supreme sense of taste. By long abandoning idle talk and speaking at the proper time, one comes to possess the mark of a jaw like a lion's. By keeping one's mind even toward all sentient beings, one comes to possess the mark of even teeth, a full forty. By delighting in reconciling disputes, one comes to possess the mark of closely fitted teeth. By making gifts of jewels, one comes to possess the mark of even teeth. Through the complete purity of body, speech, and mind, one comes to possess the mark of very white teeth. By restraining the faults of speech, one comes to possess the mark of a tongue that is very broad and thin. By always speaking gently to sentient beings, one comes to possess the mark of Brahmaghoṣa, the voice of Brahmā. By cultivating a mind of loving-kindness and looking at beings with undeluded eyes, one comes to possess the mark of eyes in which the white and the dark are clearly distinct. By wholeheartedly striving for unsurpassed awakening, one comes to possess the mark of eyelashes like a cow's. By rejoicing in and praising the merit and good qualities that others have, one comes to possess the mark of a face adorned with the ūrṇā hair. By properly serving and respecting one's elders, such as father, mother, preceptor, and master, one comes to possess the mark of a head crowned with the uṣṇīṣa. Through devotion to the teaching of the Dharma of the Great Vehicle, one comes to possess the mark of very smooth skin. By giving seats, clothing, houses, and good dwellings, one comes to possess the mark of a golden complexion. By abandoning all manner of worldly chatter, one comes to possess the mark of body hairs each curling to the right. By properly taking

up the words taught by spiritual friends, preceptors, and teachers, by increasing what one has retained, and by not letting it decline, one comes to possess the mark of body hairs curling upward. By accomplishing immeasurable good qualities, one comes to possess the mark of feet with well-raised insteps. By urging sentient beings to cultivate samādhi, one comes to possess the mark of a body whose height and breadth are equal, like a nyagrodha tree;

"Son of noble family, when a bodhisattva, a great being, accomplishes immeasurable good qualities in this way, he comes to possess the thirty-two major marks such as these." So he spoke.

Then the bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, when I examine all phenomena, none of them is established as a thing or as a sign; they do not exist. And when I examine the Tathāgata as well, that is not the conduct of the Tathāgata. Why, then, do you speak of accomplishing conduct extensively? When I examine the Three Jewels, the four truths, the aggregates, the sense sources, the elements, the twelve links of dependent origination, and the dharmas of the perfections, all outer and inner causes and results are emptiness. They are signless and wishless. I do not see them arise or come into being, nor do I see them cease or disappear. They are like an illusion, like an emanation, like a flame, like an echo, like the moon in water, like the hair of a tortoise, like the horn of a rabbit, like a flower in the sky, like the son of a barren woman, like one who wears the clothing of a reflection and seeks an illusory elephant. They are like what exists and like what does not exist. These, existent and nonexistent, are neither existent nor nonexistent. They are not permanent and not annihilated, not arising and not ceasing, not inside and not outside, not seen and not known. Since they are like space, for example, Blessed One, why did you say, 'I engaged in those forms of conduct'?

"When I examine the Tathāgata, he is not a self, not a sentient being, not a life, not a nourisher, not a man, not a person, not a possessor of strength, not a lord of strength, not an agent and so forth. He is not the eye, not form, and not the domain of the characteristics of eye and form. He is not the ear, not sound, and not the domain of the characteristics of ear and sound. He is not the nose, not smell, and not the domain of the characteristics of nose and smell. He is not the tongue, not taste, and not the domain of the characteristics of tongue and taste. He is not the body, not the tangible, and not the domain of the characteristics of body and the tangible. He is not the mind, not mental phenomena, and not the domain of the characteristics of

mind and mental phenomena either. He is not consciousness, not form, and not the domain of the characteristics of consciousness and form either. He is not form, not suffering, and not the domain of the characteristics of form and suffering either. He is not a self, not what belongs to a self, not a being who transmigrates, not one possessing form, not an aggregate, not true, not false, not gathered, not scattered, not arising, and not entering; and the same holds for feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness. He has not gone away and has not come hither, and he has no place where he abides. He has neither mind, nor mentation, nor consciousness. He has no karma of body, speech, or mind. He is neither one nor different. He is not past, not yet come, and not present. He is not defiled and not purified. He is not a self, not a sentient being, and not a life, a man, a person, or the like. He is not permanent and not annihilated. For him there is no arising and no ceasing, nothing to meditate upon and nothing to practice, nothing to discard and nothing to adopt. Since he has passed beyond the extremes and abides forever, why did you say that he accomplished conduct extensively?"

Then the Blessed One gave his approval to the bodhisattva, the great being Ākāśagarbha, saying, "Excellent, excellent! Son of noble family, in times past you rendered service to countless, immeasurable buddhas and generated roots of virtue, and for a long time you have fully understood the meaning of the unsurpassed Great Vehicle. You directly know that all phenomena whatsoever are emptiness, and you also know that the Tathāgata has passed beyond the limit of reality and abides forever. Therefore, son of noble family, it is like this. Suppose, for example, that a precious beryl (vaiḍūrya) jewel, utterly clear and bright, were left in a swamp of mud for a thousand years. Because its nature is pure, when it is taken out it is just as it was before. You too are like that. You have directly realized the characteristic of phenomena, and because your nature is utterly pure, though all of you now dwell in the mud of the five degenerations within the three realms, and though you act for the sake of the tathāgatas and of sentient beings, you are not stained by the mud. That is why you are able to ask about such matters.

"Son of noble family, listen further. It is like this: in reality, all phenomena whatsoever are without substance. It is because there are letters that phenomena are said to exist. Within phenomena there are no letters, and within letters there are no phenomena. Letters are taught in order to spread the teaching everywhere. Within letters there is no awakening, and within awakening there are no letters; yet, although ultimately there are no letters,

conventionally letters are said to exist. Therefore, for sentient beings, the very nature of a buddha and unsurpassed awakening are not found apart from letters.

"Son of noble family, what you say is also true. The Tathāgata has no exhaustion and no birth. He does not meditate and does not practice; he is free of meditation and practice. He does not enter the true Dharma, nor does he turn away from it or change. He was not born, by a single birth, in the abode of Tuṣita, nor did he descend from there to dwell in his mother's womb. Since his mind does not dwell on any phenomenon, he did not say, 'I have passed beyond birth, aging, and death.' He did not take seven steps in each of the four directions. He did not declare, 'I am the unsurpassed venerable one in the world.' In the supreme city he did not sport with lovely young women. He did not learn worldly skills such as writing and arithmetic, nor did he compete in feats of strength and archery.

"In order to lead sentient beings fully to nirvāṇa, the showing of an old man before his eyes was to put a stop to attachment to the body. The showing of a sick man before his eyes was to put a stop to attachment to life. The showing of the sign of death before his eyes was to put a stop to desire and to the grasping at I and mine. The showing of a monk before his eyes was so that sentient beings would not aspire to the bodies of Brahmā or Śakra (Indra), but would diligently accomplish the unsurpassed Dharma that transcends the world. Leaving the supreme city and departing showed liberation from the prison of the three realms and showed what is not the true fruit. Looking back once more showed that he has neither attachment nor aversion.

Therefore his body is adorned with the thirty-two major marks, and he serves as a field of merit for sentient beings. Shaving his hair, renouncing his ornaments, and sending the long-legged horse back with the faithful Chandaka showed separation from all afflictions. Shaving his beard showed nonattachment to all phenomena. Wearing the saffron robe (kāṣāya) showed the taming of sentient beings. Questioning and examining the Dharma with the sages Udraka and Ārāḍa showed the conquest of his own proud mind. Practicing austerities for six years was to tame the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas). Accepting food was to conform to the ways of the world. Accepting the svastika grass showed contentment. Sitting upon the spread grass showed the conquest of complacency and sloth. Being lauded, praised, and honored by all the gods and nāgas showed being established in the fruit of good qualities. Taming the māras showed the power of heroism. Touching the earth with his

right hand showed the power of merit. The trembling of the whole great earth showed the repaying of kindness. Thus, because he meditated without signs, he attained the path of unsurpassed awakening.

In this way, because he directly knows the characteristic of all phenomena and teaches that all phenomena are equality, he is called the Buddha. The wisdom of the Buddha is unrivaled, and because in all the Dharma he teaches he shows the meaning of attaining buddhahood, he is called the Tathāgata. Because he clearly sees and knows the deeds of the three times, virtuous and nonvirtuous dharmas, he is called the Omniscient One. Because he speaks truly and correctly, he is called the preceptor of gods and humans. Whoever trains and reflects in this way is called a bodhisattva. One who conceives of this wrongly is not called a bodhisattva; he is called a deceiver of all the buddhas. Son of noble family, all the buddhas neither come forth nor enter, are neither born nor cease. It is in order to lead all sentient beings to nirvāṇa that it is said, 'They appear in the world,' and said, 'The Buddha passes into nirvāṇa.'"

Then the bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, I too realize that in reality the essential nature of all phenomena is emptiness. Since the Tathāgata has no arising or setting, he was not born in the royal palace, nor did he pass into nirvāṇa at the foot of the tree of awakening. He has passed beyond the extremes and abides forever. In order to liberate sentient beings fully, he displays the practice of austerities and the passing into nirvāṇa, yet in reality he has no change and no elaboration, and he abides in the domain of the Tathāgata. Even the bodies that appear in the three realms are the dharma body appearing in five aspects. What are the five? They are as follows: the body of true essential nature, the body possessed of good qualities, the body born from the essential nature of the Dharma, the body that emanates and appears, and the body like space.

"Of these, what is called the body of true essential nature is the supreme true fruit, which transcends all signs and abides forever in its own sphere; therefore it is called the body of true essential nature. What is called the body possessed of good qualities performs conduct of many kinds in order to lead sentient beings to nirvāṇa and brings all virtue to perfection; therefore it is called the body possessed of good qualities. What is called the body born from the essential nature of the Dharma comprehends all the characteristics of phenomena, so that there is nothing it does not know; it is born from the emptiness that truly knows that domain and is perfectly complete; therefore it

is called the body born from the essential nature of the Dharma. What is called the body that emanates and appears is this: when the Tathāgata appears in the world, there is no one in the five destinies, whether virtuous or evil, to whom he does not manifest and for whom he does not become a refuge; since from emanated substance he takes on the marks, it is called the body that emanates and appears. As for what is called the body like space: since space is limitless, the dharma body too is limitless. Since space cannot be gauged or measured, the dharma body too cannot be gauged or measured. The body of the Tathāgata is like great space, and since he shows five kinds of body in order to lead sentient beings fully to nirvāṇa, it is evident that the Tathāgata has no birth and no cessation. All phenomena are likewise: it is in order to lead sentient beings fully to nirvāṇa that the buddhas manifest emanations and spread the Dharma."

Then the Blessed One said to the bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha, "Son of noble family, like the Tathāgata you are skilled in the characteristics of phenomena, and therefore in every domain you have no barrier or obstruction. Son of noble family, in the future, in the eon called Thousandfold Utterly Pure, in the world called Endowed with Enjoyments, there will be only bodhisattvas, great beings, who practice the Great Vehicle alone. There even the names of the vehicles of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas will never reach the ear, so what need is there to mention the lower realms? In that eon and in that world you will appear as the tathāgata, arhat, perfectly complete buddha called Utterly Pure Ornament. Great beings from other worlds will also go there and will listen to, take up, and keep the Great Vehicle sūtra the Liberation Extending in All Directions. Therefore, whatever sentient beings hear the name of the bodhisattva Ākāśagarbha and pay homage and make offerings will be born in that realm, the world Endowed with Enjoyments. Whatever sentient beings practice the Dharma of the Great Vehicle will attain acceptance of the nonarising of phenomena. Whoever takes up and keeps this Dharma discourse will receive a prophecy before ten buddhas have appeared."

At that time, the bodhisattva Faith in Characteristics made a request to the Blessed One Śākyamuni for the sake of himself and all sentient beings. The Blessed One taught the names of the buddhas of the ten directions and the three times, the names of the twelve branches of the scriptures, and the names of the Saṅgha of bodhisattvas, and then he again proclaimed a great lion's roar. What is called the lion's roar is the teaching of the definitive word. The teaching of the definitive word is to know that the Tathāgata always lives,

endures, and remains, and does not pass into nirvāṇa.

Moreover, teaching that all sentient beings have the buddha nature, and humbling the divine māras, the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), and the like, so that they come under the power of the refuge: this is what is called the lion's roar.

Having taught in this way, with the great mark of his tongue he covered the entire great trichiliocosm, all its world systems, and all the world systems quaked in six ways. What is called quaking in six ways is this: when the east rises, the west sinks; when the west rises, the east sinks; when the south rises, the north sinks; when the north rises, the south sinks; when the center rises, the edges sink; and when the edges rise, the center sinks. This is called the earth quaking in six ways.

From the root of his tongue he sent forth great rays of light and made a great illumination in the ten directions. That great illumination made the impermanent permanent, made the impure pure, made those who suffer happy, and turned ignorance into knowledge. At that time, wherever the light of the Buddha touched and shone, the mountains, forests, lands, rivers, oceans, the encircling iron mountains, the hells, and all the rest became level, without high or low places, without unevenness or roughness, and everything became utterly pure, so that it was, for example, like the world Full Moon, Utterly Pure and Thoroughly Adorned, in the east.

At that time, the emanated bodies of the Blessed One Śākyamuni descended from the sky like a falling rain of flowers, and they came forth from beneath the earth like rising clouds and mist, until they filled the whole of space and not the slightest empty space was left. From the mouth of each emanation, in unison, they declared, "The Tathāgata always lives, endures, and remains, and does not pass into nirvāṇa. All sentient beings have the buddha nature." They also declared, "All phenomena are emptiness." They explained, "The causes and results of those forms of conduct come down to a single vehicle, yet sentient beings see them as three vehicles," and immediately all of them vanished, and only the Blessed One seated on his seat could be seen.

That the whole great assembly then saw those emanated bodies was through the power of the blessing of the Blessed One Śākyamuni. When Śākyamuni, out of loving-kindness, manifested such miracles and splendor, bodhisattvas from among the assembly as numerous as the grains of sand in forty Ganges rivers attained acceptance of the nonarising of phenomena. Eighty thousand śrāvakas generated the mind of the Great Vehicle. Ten thousand monks

attained the path of the arhat. Eighteen thousand nuns attained the path of the non-returner. Four hundred thousand laymen attained the path of the once-returner. One million laywomen attained the path of the stream-enterer. Countless gods and humans attained the pure eye of the Dharma, free of dust and stainless; they knew their own former and later lives, and they saw all conditioned phenomena as impermanent.

Then from among the assembly the bodhisattva, the great being Siṃhanāda, rose from his seat, draped his upper robe over one shoulder, touched his head to the feet of the Blessed One in homage, and said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, according to what the Blessed One taught above, hearing the name of the Buddha purifies wrongdoing, hearing the name of the Dharma purifies wrongdoing, and hearing the name of the Saṅgha purifies wrongdoing. Is this the power of the Buddha, the power of the Dharma, or the power of the Saṅgha? If it is the power of the Buddha, one would make supplication to the Buddha. If it is the power of the Dharma, one would make supplication to the Dharma. If it is the power of the Saṅgha, one would make supplication to the Saṅgha. So why must one make supplication to all three? And it was said above that ordinary beings see the one vehicle as three; if the Blessed One himself also explains it as three, what need is there to speak of sentient beings?"

The Blessed One said to the bodhisattva, the great being Siṃhanāda, "Excellent, excellent! Son of noble family, it is very good that you ask about such a matter for the benefit and happiness of sentient beings. Listen, and I will explain it to you, drawing the distinctions. It is not the power of the Buddha alone, nor the power of the Dharma alone, nor the power of the Saṅgha alone. Through the power of all of them together, the Buddha is the protector and refuge of sentient beings, their father and mother, and the bodhisattvas are their spiritual friends. If corrupted sentient beings who have lost their minds regain them, grow weary of saṃsāra, and, through the great power of mindfulness, wish to cross over the ocean of afflictions within the three realms, then this sūtra Extending in All Directions becomes the great ship that carries them across. Therefore, son of noble family, the Buddha is the Dharma, and the Dharma is the Saṅgha. The Saṅgha is the unconditioned. The unconditioned is emptiness: the emptiness of the unconditioned, the emptiness of the conditioned, inner emptiness, outer emptiness, great emptiness, and small emptiness are all alike as emptiness, and there is nothing other than that.

"Son of noble family, as to what you say, 'Why must what is accomplished in a single way be accomplished in three ways?', son of noble family, it is like this. Suppose, for example, that a man is frightened of empty space. Wherever he goes to hide, he is never separated from space. Son of noble family, what the tathāgatas of the ten directions have taught and all that I have taught, the causes and conditions of all virtue, the Three Jewels, and the three vehicles, do not go beyond one."

The bodhisattva Siṃhanāda said, "Excellent, excellent! Blessed One, I already knew what the Noble One has taught; I asked about this matter for the sake of sentient beings. As the Blessed One has said, it is not two and not three. This Dharma discourse, the Great Liberation Extending in All Directions, is the mother of the buddhas, the great path of the bodhisattvas, and the eye of the yogis. In order to gather in those with wrong views, to protect those who have lost their minds, to close the doors of the three lower realms, to open the door of unsurpassed awakening, and to turn back the śrāvakas and lead them into the Great Vehicle, I shall guard and protect it with the mantra of the great dhāraṇī.

Those who keep their vows unbroken and who meditate on and train in this sūtra, them too I shall guard and protect. If, while some person is honoring this sūtra and carrying out its practice for seven days, the evil Māra should disturb them and look for an opening, I shall see to it that the evil Māra finds no opportunity for an opening. Blessed One, I shall serve this sūtra, and to make it endure for a long time, I shall make it remain until I arrive at the seat of awakening.

The Blessed One said, "Son of noble family, your serving this sūtra is like serving the Three Jewels. It is also like serving the Teacher."

Then the bodhisattva Siṃhanāda spoke this dhāraṇī-mantra in the presence of the Blessed One:

namo buddhāya namo dharmāya namaḥ saṅghāya adanti dhāraṇī tadyathā ākāśa nibabīni sarba dharmā nibani iśamada pipaśana pimalasupari dharmanikhana bararunicayatamale cale hulu hulu śibite mantra mantra mantraḥ svāhā

"This mantra should be recited one hundred and eight times in a single session, and one should circumambulate a stūpa seven times. In this way, for seven days, without thinking of other sūtras, one should, even within a single day, at the three times, focus single-pointedly on this sūtra, Extending in All

Directions, without letting the mind wander elsewhere.

"Blessed One, this dhāraṇī-mantra has been spoken by eight million buddhas, and today, here, I too have recited it. If anyone should disparage this dhāraṇī, they would be disparaging those buddhas. One who disparages this dhāraṇī, even if they strive for awakening through many lifetimes, will not attain it, and will not pass beyond the three realms of existence. Why is that? Because this mantra makes those whose mind and mindfulness have failed regain their minds. And if a person hears this dhāraṇī even once, or, having heard it, writes it down, does not eat meat or drink alcohol, abides in the vows, gives up frivolity and the like, does not enter into busy crowds, constantly practices great loving-kindness, and holds meditative concentration dear, that person will be purified of the immeasurable heavy evils of the three obscurations. If, as soon as one hears this dhāraṇī, one takes it up wholeheartedly, holds it, reads it every day, recites it by heart, and does not let it lapse as a pledged practice, that person will not fall into the three lower realms until attaining full awakening."

When he had said this, the Blessed One said to the bodhisattva Siṃhanāda, "Excellent, excellent! Son of noble family, that you have taught this dhāraṇī-mantra in order to serve the Three Jewels, to draw sentient beings out of the three realms of existence with a mind of loving-kindness, to benefit the countless many who are in training and bring them great happiness, to open the door of the Teacher, and to turn back wrong views and lead beings into right view, is excellent indeed. Son of noble family, if any sentient beings hear your name and the sound of the mantra, give rise to faith and respect, and do not disparage it, that person will be happy in this very life, and when they die and pass on they will always see all the buddhas, will see me as well, and will also see all the bodhisattvas, such as you. They will also know for certain, by themselves, that they will attain full awakening, without any doubt.

"Having abandoned all the afflictions,
And accomplished the path of every virtue,
One sees the intrinsic nature of the buddhas
Through the power of pure faith."

And again the Blessed One spoke these words: "After my nirvāṇa, if any son or daughter of noble family, for one day, or one session, or one night, or a single instant, pays homage to the buddhas who have gone in the ten directions and the three times, to the twelve sections of the sūtras, and to the great Saṅgha

of bodhisattvas, attends properly to the Great Vehicle, and contemplates the ultimate truth, then that person, in no more than the instant of a finger snap, will be purified, entirely and without remainder, of the ten non-virtues, the five acts of immediate retribution, the denigration of sameness, and all the karma of affliction.

"If a monk, a nun, a bodhisattva, a male renunciant or a female renunciant, having lost the nature of the mind, has broken the four roots and the eight vows, has committed the ten non-virtues and the five acts of immediate retribution, and has denigrated sameness, and then gives rise to faith in the names of the buddhas who have gone in the ten directions and the three times and pays them homage, all such evil karma will be purified without remainder."

No sooner had he spoken these words than the one who, in the past, at the time of the Buddha Unchanging Light, had been the prince called Seeing Virtue, arrived in that very instant together with three thousand people. They bowed their heads at the feet of the Blessed One, paid homage, and with one voice said this to the Blessed One: "From countless eons onward, the afflicted karma we have committed could never be fully told. The ten non-virtues, the five acts of immediate retribution, and the countless evils of denigrating sameness that we have committed, relying on the twelve sections of the Tathāgata's sūtras, we confess in the presence of the Saṅgha of bodhisattvas, and we ask to make amends with remorse. Would you grant us the opportunity?"

The Blessed One said, "Excellent, excellent! Son of noble family, it is difficult to give rise to a mind of fear, and difficult to give rise to roots of virtue. You who wish to confess and lay aside the ten non-virtues and the five acts of immediate retribution are close to seeing the very being of the Buddha, the enjoyment body and the rest. So confess and acknowledge them, just as you remember them in your minds."

Then Prince Seeing Virtue and the rest of the three thousand people, having heard the loving words of the Blessed One granting them the opportunity, arranged their robes, joined their palms, paid homage, draped their upper robes over the right shoulder, placed the right knee on the ground, and said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, we go for refuge to the buddhas of the ten directions. We go for refuge to the Dharma of the ten directions. We go for refuge to the Saṅgha of the ten directions. And further, namely: we pay

homage and go for refuge to the buddha of the east, Akṣobhya."

"We pay homage and go for refuge to the buddha of the south, Ratnasambhava. We pay homage and go for refuge to the buddha of the west, Amitābha. We pay homage and go for refuge to the buddha of the north, Amoghasiddhi. We pay homage and go for refuge to the buddha of the zenith, Gandhakūṭa. We pay homage and go for refuge to the buddha of the nadir, Hundred Thousand Reflections.

"Further, we pay homage and go for refuge to the great being Samantabhadra in the east. We pay homage and go for refuge to the great being Lokadhara in the south. We pay homage and go for refuge to the all-seeing Avalokiteśvara in the west. We pay homage and go for refuge to Pūrṇacandra in the north. We pay homage and go for refuge to Ākāśagarbha in the zenith. We pay homage and go for refuge to the great being Steadfast Glory in the nadir.

"Further, we pay homage and go for refuge also to our preceptor, the Tathāgata Unchanging Light. We pay homage and go for refuge to the very being of the buddhas who have not yet come. We pay homage and go for refuge also to the emanation bodies of the buddhas in other directions. We pay homage and go for refuge also to our present preceptor, the Blessed One Śākyamuni. We pay homage and go for refuge also to the great being Vimalakīrti and to the youthful Mañjuśrī. We pay homage and go for refuge also to the noble Nanda and Kāśyapa. We pay homage and go for refuge also to those in whom the four kinds of noble fruit are manifest. We pay homage and go for refuge also to those who have first given rise to the awakening mind. We pay homage and go for refuge also to the great canon, the twelve sections of scripture, and to all the other sūtras of authentic sameness that we know to exist. We pay homage and go for refuge also to the stūpas that contain the bodily remains and relics divided into eight portions. We pay homage and go for refuge also to all the images that exist at present.

"Four Great Kings of the four directions, Brahmā, Śakra (Indra), lord of the gods of the Thirty-Three, gods who dwell in the sky, gods of the earth, gods of the mountains, of the forests and of the foot of trees, sages, those possessed of the bases of miraculous power, those who have the divine eye, and all who have the divine ear, please hear us with your ears and take note! We call upon you all as our witnesses: even if, among all sentient beings, there is any evil that has not been confessed and acknowledged, may all evil be purified!"

And they spoke further, saying: "From beginningless time until we obtained this present wretched body, with erring and deluded minds and wrong views, we have committed immeasurable afflicted and non-virtuous karma that words cannot fully express. We know that we have committed masses of evil. Unaware ourselves, through ignorance our evil minds grew greatly. Not seeing the next life and seeing only this life, we delighted in the habitual tendencies of the afflictions and became far removed from the roots of virtue. Cut off by bad karma, we kept company with evil friends. We committed improper and unseemly acts toward monks and nuns, and committed improper and unseemly acts toward father and mother. Moreover, through our own degeneration we used the property of the Saṅgha as we pleased, and acted improperly and unseemly toward the Saṅgha of the five groups. We proclaimed the worldly fruits of affliction to be immeasurable, or killed sentient beings who possessed roots of virtue directed toward awakening, or disparaged teachers of the Dharma, disparaging the Dharma by saying it is not the Dharma and declaring what is not the Dharma to be the Dharma. We said that the Tathāgata is impermanent. We said that the sublime Dharma too is impermanent. We said that the jewel of the Saṅgha too is impermanent. We had no inclination toward generosity and wisdom. Because we placed our faith in false teachings and held to them, today our fear and dread are immeasurable, and our shame and embarrassment too are immeasurable, and so we go for refuge to the Three Jewels. The buddhas, the blessed ones, possess loving-kindness and compassion; they are father and mother, impartial toward all. The bodhisattvas are spiritual friends. Therefore, since we wish to confess and acknowledge the evil we have committed in saṃsāra over countless eons, we beg you to grant us the opportunity, and we resolve never to do it again.

"Further, Blessed One, from immeasurable eons until now we have committed the five acts of immediate retribution, destroyed the trainings of the buddhas who have gone in the three times, engaged in sexual misconduct, uttered harsh speech, and committed the evil karma of disparaging the sublime Dharma, and we have never felt remorse for these deeds or confessed them. Without remorse or shame in our minds, although we ourselves knew that we had certainly committed heavy, evil, non-virtuous karma, the ten non-virtues, the five acts of immediate retribution and the rest, we concealed our faults, and from the very beginning we had no mind of fear and dread, nor of remorse and shame. We accepted the offerings of the faithful, yet never confessed and

acknowledged. Having no intention to establish the sublime Dharma for a long time and to serve it, we constantly disparaged it and held it in contempt. We committed many afflicted faults by way of speech, and we even deliberately declared that the Three Jewels do not exist. Because we have committed the ten non-virtues and those evils of immediate retribution, today our fear and dread are immeasurable, and our remorse and shame are immeasurable, and so we go for refuge to the Three Jewels. The buddhas, the blessed ones, possess loving-kindness and compassion; they are father and mother, impartial toward all. The bodhisattvas are spiritual friends. Therefore, since we wish, with minds that conceal nothing, to confess and acknowledge the evil we have committed in saṃsāra over countless eons, we beg you to grant us the opportunity, and we resolve never to do it again."

"Further, Blessed One, from countless eons until now we have looked with inverted views. We declared the four roots to be grave offenses, and grave offenses to be the four roots. We declared what was broken to be unbroken, and what was unbroken to be broken. We declared heavy offenses to be light, and light ones to be heavy. We declared what was pure to be impure, and what was impure to be pure. Moreover, through wrong views we extolled and praised worldly treatises, while showing no respect for the Dharma and the sūtras, and we always engaged in and spoke vile talk. We kept the eight kinds of unexamined possessions. We called the true word of the Tathāgata the word of Māra, and what was truly the word of Māra we called the word of the Tathāgata. We held the words of the tīrthikas to be trustworthy. We said that the Tathāgata in the end passed into nirvāṇa and no longer exists, and that therefore the Three Jewels too are impermanent. Because our bodies and minds were deluded and our inverted views were immeasurable, today our fear and dread are immeasurable, and our remorse and shame too are immeasurable, and so we go for refuge to the Three Jewels. The buddhas, the blessed ones, possess loving-kindness and compassion; they are father and mother, impartial toward all. The bodhisattvas are spiritual friends. Therefore, since we wish, with minds that conceal nothing, to confess and acknowledge those evils we have committed in saṃsāra over countless eons, we beg you to grant us the opportunity, and we resolve never to do them again.

"Further, Blessed One, from immeasurable eons until reaching this present life and body, we have stolen, or used as we pleased, the property of the Saṅgha at large, or the property of the Saṅgha of the ten directions, or the property of the Saṅgha now in residence, or the property of the Saṅgha of the five groups,

or the property of an individual monk, or the wealth and goods of any donor. And further, boasting of ourselves, we said, 'I have attained the sublime Dharma, the four meditative concentrations, or the four fruits,' when we had not attained them. Conditions such as these became causes and conditions of evil, non-virtuous karma, so that even after going forth from home into homelessness, we broke each of these disciplines, from minor wrongdoings all the way up to defeat: the four defeats, the eight vows, the six, the thirteen saṅghāvaśeṣas, the two undetermined matters, the thirty downfalls involving forfeiture, the ninety downfalls, the four to be individually confessed, the many trainings, and the seven very weighty rules. We committed the five acts of immediate retribution, disparaged the sublime Dharma and the profound sūtras, and engaged in sexual misconduct, and since we concealed our faults and never felt remorse or confessed, these have increased and grown day and night.

"We have heard what the Victors taught of old: 'If those who disparage the sublime Dharma, or who have committed the five acts of immediate retribution, or who have been defeated in the four roots, do not confess and acknowledge them, those sentient beings will certainly fall into hell. Even the tathāgatas, the bodhisattvas, the śrāvakas and the pratyekabuddhas will not give them protection, and neither the Saṅgha, nor father and mother, nor the gods, nor humans can give them refuge or help.' Because this has been said, today our fear and dread are immeasurable, and our remorse and shame are immeasurable. Therefore, today we go for refuge to the Three Jewels, to the past buddha Prabhūtaratna, to the thousand buddhas of the future, and to the presently living buddha, the emanation body Śākyamuni. The buddhas, the blessed ones, are lords of loving-kindness and compassion; they are father and mother, impartial toward all. The bodhisattvas are spiritual friends. Therefore, since we wish to confess and acknowledge the afflictive obscurations, the karmic obscurations and the cognitive obscurations we have had from immeasurable eons until now, along with the heavy evils of the four defeats, the acts of immediate retribution, the ten non-virtues and the rest, we beg you to grant us the opportunity.

"Further, Blessed One, today, for the sake of sentient beings and for the sake of each of ourselves, we now wish to confess and acknowledge in the presence of the Victors of the ten directions. From immeasurable eons until now, all sentient beings have failed to appreciate the kindness of the tathāgatas and of their fathers and mothers. Not knowing the Dharma of purification, they have

done all kinds of non-virtue. Proud of their lineage, in their arrogance and conceit they carelessly committed afflicted karma, yet did not see it as a fault, and so did the deeds of foolish people. They relied on evil friends, and their minds were agitated by the afflictions. Insatiable for the five qualities of sense pleasure, they committed non-virtuous deeds. Deceived by beautiful women, tormented by the afflictions of desire, aversion and delusion, their minds were agitated. The non-virtuous karma accumulated through conceptual elaboration and through the three doors of body, speech and mind, which we ourselves have done, which we have caused others to do, and in whose doing we have rejoiced, all of it we today individually confess. We acknowledge it. We do not conceal it. The evil of not having honored the Buddha, the Dharma and the noble Saṅgha, that too we today individually confess. We acknowledge it. We do not conceal it. The evil of not having honored the bodhisattvas and pratyekabuddhas either, that too we today individually confess. We acknowledge it. We do not conceal it. The evils of having disparaged the sublime Dharma under the sway of ignorance, and of not having honored father and mother, preceptor and teacher because we failed to appreciate their kindness, those too we today individually confess. We acknowledge them. We do not conceal them. The evils of all kinds of non-virtue committed while obscured by foolishness and bewilderment, through complacency and conceit, those too we today individually confess. We acknowledge them. We do not conceal them. We shall never do them again.

"Through our making gifts and offerings to all the buddhas of the ten directions, may all sentient beings without exception be established on the ten grounds, and fully and manifestly awaken into perfect awakening as tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas!"

Then the Blessed One spoke these words to Prince Seeing Virtue:

"Excellent, great being! You are skilled at examining the good and bad of your own actions. Having given rise to fear and dread of afflicted karma, you have not only openly confessed your own faults, but have also confessed and acknowledged the many evils of sentient beings, and therefore you are called a truly excellent person. Not only have you abandoned your own afflictions, but you have also set sentient beings far apart from affliction, and therefore you are called a truly excellent person. You did not make aspirations for your own sake; from the very first you made the aspiration to fully and manifestly awaken into unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening for the sake of all sentient beings, and therefore you are called a truly excellent person, a truly

excellent person."

Then, after they had made amends with remorse, the three thousand people, Prince Seeing Virtue and the others, praised the Blessed One in these verses:

"Blessed One, sole and supreme lord,
Father and mother of the three realms, knower of all,
Unequaled by all, yet sameness itself,
To the rare Blessed One we pay homage.

"People give gifts for their own sake;
They give wealth and goods, and hope for a return.
The Victor of great love is not like that:
To foe and friend alike he gives love and help.

"Among the two-legged, the Victor is venerable;
With the eye of wisdom he knows and sees.
To you of great diligence I go for refuge;
Other gods do not know such wisdom.

"To those past, those not yet come, and those now present,
To all the Victors I pay homage.
Likewise, going for refuge to the Victor
Is like worshiping the Victors of the three times."

Then the buddhas of the ten directions addressed Prince Seeing Virtue and the three thousand people in verses of praise:

"Whoever wishes to attain buddhahood
Should follow the learned.
If you honor a virtuous teacher,
Buddhahood will not be long in coming.

"Whoever practices pure moral discipline,
That one is a true monk.
Whoever is able to meditate on emptiness,
That one is said to have attained samādhi.
Whoever is able to practice diligence,
That is the practice of awakening.
Whoever will pass into nirvāṇa,
That is true joy.

"Monks who keep moral discipline,
And nuns who keep pure discipline,

Hold the poṣadha every half month!
Wear the robes upon your bodies,
Carry the alms bowl and the cymbal,
And go on pure alms rounds;
Then all the gods will be delighted,
Will join their palms, and bow respectfully.
I too shall have all gods and humans
Carry out their tasks for them,
Just as all the servant gods
Respectfully serve
Śakra, lord of the gods.
Even now, right away, they gain the reward,
And in later times it is beyond measure.
To go forth and keep the discipline
Is called repaying the Buddha's kindness.

"Prince Seeing Virtue, it is like this:
Apart from me and the bodhisattvas,
Even all worldly people
Give rise to minds of pure faith.
All those buddhas of the ten directions
Do not pass into nirvāṇa; they always remain,
And so too the Dharma and the Saṅgha.
To understand clearly in this way
Is called repaying the Buddha's kindness.

"Prince Seeing Virtue, it is like this:
All worldly people
Lack a discerning mind
And do not clearly know the one vehicle.
The buddhas past and future,
Of the ten directions and of the present,
Have only the one Great Vehicle,
Without anything called two or three.
If, having generated this in mind,
One's mind does not conceptualize,
Such people
Are said to repay the Victor's kindness.

"Prince Seeing Virtue, it is like this:
If some persons,
After the Buddha's nirvāṇa,
Always give rise to faith
And teach that in all sentient beings
The very being of a buddha is present,
Such persons
Are said to repay the Victor's kindness.

"Whoever practices virtue for an instant,
Not hoping for the fruit of the gods,
And all at once accomplishes the unsurpassed path,
Is said to repay the Victor's kindness.

"Prince Seeing Virtue, it is like this:
After the Buddha's nirvāṇa,
If some persons
Read this sūtra for even a moment,
Show respect to the Three Jewels,
And serve and make offerings to their preceptor,
Such persons
Are said to repay the Victor's kindness.

"Whoever gives some few kinds of wealth and goods,
Or food and clothing,
Extending the gift to all,
Is said to repay the Victor's kindness.

"Prince Seeing Virtue, it is like this:
When my teachings are being destroyed,
If someone, having turned another's mind toward it,
Listens to this sūtra for even a moment,
That surpasses making offerings
To ten million bodhisattvas.
These Great Vehicle sūtras
Are the mother of the awakening of all buddhas.
If one keeps in mind the buddhas, the bodhisattvas,
And this sūtra,
With an even mind free of the duality of self and other,
That is called repaying the Victor's kindness.

"Prince Seeing Virtue, it is like this:
When this Dharma is being destroyed,
If one, wishing to repay the Victor's kindness,
Meditates for an instant, a single moment,
Then, compared with giving the gift of life
To the beings that fill a thousandfold world,
Meditating in concentration is of greater merit.
Whoever disparages meditation
And sows discord in the Saṅgha
Is like one who cuts off the lives of the people
Filling the threefold thousand worlds,
And kills every living creature;
Such a one's evil is just like that.
Whoever, on seeing someone practicing virtue,
Disparages them and lacks faith
Cuts off the lineage of the Three Jewels,
And does not repay the Victor."

Then Prince Seeing Virtue and the three thousand people, satisfied with joy at the teaching the blessed ones had granted, received that very teaching upon the crowns of their heads and spoke these verses:

"In the teaching of the Blessed One,
What is many, and what is not many?
Both many and not many
Are never found as observable things.
Such is the true characteristic;
It does not contradict any phenomena.
Out of love for all sentient beings,
You turn the wheel of the Dharma with skillful means.
From wherever the noble ones have come,
From there the Tathāgata too has come.
Just as the true characteristic is,
So too is the Tathāgata."

"Just as the true words of all the noble ones,
So too the Tathāgata has spoken.
For that reason the Victor's name
Is called Tathāgata.

"With mind made firm by the armor of patience,
Great diligence, the strength of a hard bow,
And swift wisdom, the sharp arrow,
He conquers the enemies of laziness;
And since he accepts the offerings
Presented by the gods and humans of the world,
For that reason the Victor's name
Is called Arhat.

"He knows fully the characteristic of suffering,
And knows thoroughly the cause of suffering;
Of the characteristic of suffering's cessation,
He fully knows the way to peace as well.
Since he knows the four noble truths,
Certain that they are true and unchanging,
Therefore, throughout the ten directions,
His name is called Perfectly Complete Buddha.

"Having gained the supreme three knowledges,
And endowed with pure conduct as well,
For that reason the Blessed One's name
Is called Endowed with Knowledge and Conduct.

"Knowing all phenomena completely,
Having fully attained the sublime nature of reality,
Out of love for all,
He teaches with skillful means, suited to the occasion.
He utterly dispels birth, aging, sickness and death,
And brings beings to the state of bliss.
For that reason the Victor's name
Is called Sugata.

"He knows where the world comes from,
And also the end where the world is spent.
For that reason the Victor's name
Is called Knower of the World.

"With great compassion he frees sentient beings;
Gently he teaches virtue and tames them.
For that reason the Victor's name
Is Charioteer Who Tames Persons.

"In discipline, samādhi and the eye of wisdom
He has mastered all, and none surpasses him.
For that reason the Victor's name
Is called Unsurpassed.

"Free of afflictions, endowed with wisdom,
He teaches liberation, sublime and supreme.
For that reason the Victor's name
Is called Teacher of Gods and Humans.

"Moving or unmoving in the three times,
All phenomena, spent or unspent,
He knew completely at the foot of the tree of awakening.
For that reason his name is Buddha."

Then the buddhas of the ten directions entered the samādhi of great miraculous power, rose bodily into the sky, and from each of their mouths spoke in unison these words: "O Prince Seeing Virtue and you three thousand people, the nature of your evil does not abide within, does not abide outside, and does not abide in between. Because the mind is firm, the power of virtue too is firm. Because the mind is liberated, the nature of evil too is liberated. Because wisdom is emptiness, the nature of evil too is emptiness. Because the power of faith is great, the power of merit too is great. Likewise, those who are able to confess, acknowledge and make amends with remorse will not only see us, but will also see the Buddha Prabhūtaratna and all the emanation bodies."

"When evil has been purified through remorse, one will continually see me as well. Making amends with remorse in this way, in accord with what has been taught today to the bodhisattvas, will delight me, the emanation bodies, and all the past buddhas such as Prabhūtaratna. One will have seen the buddhas of the ten directions and the three times and made offerings to them. They too will be delighted, and, following this Great Vehicle sūtra, one will attain awakening."

The Blessed One said to the members of the assembly who were further off: "If evildoers wish to confess their evil, then if, like Prince Seeing Virtue, they focus one by one on the buddhas of the three times, the twelve sections of the sūtras and the great Saṅgha of bodhisattvas, and pay homage, generating the perception that it is like meeting me or like seeing me; if they generate the perception of one buddha, or two buddhas, or ten buddhas, or a hundred buddhas, or a thousand buddhas, or ten thousand buddhas, or countless

buddhas, focusing on them as if seeing them; and if in the same way they focus on them one by one and pay homage with the mind, they will obtain immeasurable merit and will clear away all the heavy evils of saṃsāra. For countless eons they will not fall into the three lower realms, and it is certain, beyond doubt, that they will abide happily in the Buddha's Dharma. Therefore, if one confesses and acknowledges one's evils and gives rise to faith from the depths of the heart, the evil will without question be purified."

Then Prince Seeing Virtue and the three thousand people raised their voices together and offered the Blessed One this praise in verse:

"Blessed One, loving and of great compassion,
Of the Śākya lineage, lord of the Dharma,
With a lion's roar amid the assembly
You gather in sentient beings everywhere,
Like a father who looks upon his only son,
Never making any distinction.
Having seen one so unsurpassed,
Therefore we bow with respect."

Then the Blessed One said this to Prince Seeing Virtue and the three thousand people: "Sons of noble family, since you have made amends with remorse in this way and have confessed and acknowledged with minds that conceal nothing, you are now called bodhisattvas. In a future time you will without question attain buddhahood.

"Further, sons of noble family, it is like this: after my nirvāṇa, whoever is able, from the depths of the heart, to pay homage to the tathāgatas of the ten directions, the twelve sections of the sūtras and the Saṅgha of bodhisattvas is said to repay the kindness of the Three Jewels. At once the evils of the ten non-virtues, the five acts of immediate retribution and the denigration of sameness are purified. Then, to one fit to be a stream-enterer it grants the fruit of stream-entry. To one fit to be a once-returner it grants the fruit of once-returning. To one fit to be a non-returner it grants the fruit of non-returning. To one fit to be an arhat it grants the fruit of arhatship. To one fit to be a pratyekabuddha it grants the fruit of a pratyekabuddha. To one fit to be a bodhisattva it grants the fruit of a bodhisattva.

"Now, within this sūtra, that the bodhisattva great beings attain the true characteristic in a single birth is the reward of paying homage to the buddhas of the ten directions and the three times. That bodhisattvas attain the realm of

phenomena in two births is also the reward of paying homage to the buddhas of the three times. That bodhisattvas attain the wisdom that has reached the true limit is also the reward of paying homage to the buddhas of the three times."

"That some bodhisattvas comprehend the ultimate truth is also the reward of paying homage to the buddhas of the three times. That some bodhisattvas possess the samādhi of heroic progress (śūraṃgama) is also the reward of paying homage to the buddhas of the three times. That some bodhisattvas possess the sky treasury (gaganagañja) samādhi and the samādhi of the seal of wisdom is also the reward of paying homage to the buddhas of the three times. That some bodhisattvas possess irreversible patience, the patience of the gift of the Dharma, and the realm that accords with the Dharma is also the reward of paying homage to the buddhas of the three times. That some bodhisattvas possess the mind of the great mindfulness of dhāraṇī and self-aware wisdom is also the reward of paying homage to the buddhas gone in the three times. That some bodhisattvas possess the Siṃhanāda samādhi, the Vajra samādhi, and the samādhi of the seal of the five wisdoms is also the reward of paying homage to the buddhas gone in the three times. That some bodhisattvas possess the samādhi of equality, great loving-kindness, great compassion, and the conduct of an unsurpassed, perfectly complete buddha is also the reward of paying homage to the buddhas gone in the three times."

Then the bodhisattva great being, the Dharma Lord Mañjuśrī, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, all sentient beings are mistaken and deluded, their minds disturbed. How should those who have committed non-virtue and the acts of immediate retribution act, so that their misdeeds may be purified?"

The Blessed One declared to Mañjuśrī: "It was taught above. Whoever, having heard this extensive Dharma discourse and the names of the buddhas of the ten directions and the three times, of the twelve divisions of scripture, and of the bodhisattvas, gives rise to joy and to great delight, and with immeasurable faith and reverence takes it up, holds it, reads it, recites it, writes it out, or masters it completely, should then make a maṇḍala inside a single secluded dwelling and sprinkle it with scented water. Adorning it with fine banners and parasols and burning fragrant resin incense, one should invite the Victors and request them to come; whether many or few, having invited them, one should bathe oneself clean and put on clean clothes, and each time one goes outside to relieve oneself, one should bathe once again. Setting up a lion throne, one should meditate on this Dharma discourse for a long time, and should clearly

realize the characteristic of phenomena without any view of a self, a person, a sentient being, and so forth; a beginner should distinguish the particulars and state them clearly. Then, burning fragrant incense and dispelling the agitated mind, with right mindfulness and right thought one should think one-pointedly of the Tathāgata.

"For those who practice in this way, harmony and concord are supreme. Discord and quarrelling among them will not amount to confession; such anger destroys everything and is also contrary to proper conduct. Recollecting the Great Vehicle and contemplating the ultimate, one must not lie down or fall asleep for seven days and nights. Even in a single day one should recite or read this sūtra at the three times, doing so at the six periods of day and night, making offerings of incense, paying homage, and confessing. When one listens to this sūtra, one should recite the names of the buddhas, the bodhisattvas, and the twelve divisions of scripture, and from the depths of one's heart be undisturbed; from the depths of one's heart be unmistaken; from the depths of one's heart be undistracted; from the depths of one's heart be diligent at the proper times; from the depths of one's heart be diligent day after day; from the depths of one's heart give rise to faith; from the depths of one's heart give rise to joy; from the depths of one's heart give rise to devotion; from the depths of one's heart be unceasing; from the depths of one's heart be careful; from the depths of one's heart be unseparated; from the depths of one's heart not think of misdeeds; from the depths of one's heart recollect the Buddha; from the depths of one's heart recollect the Dharma; from the depths of one's heart recollect the Saṅgha; from the depths of one's heart recollect moral discipline; from the depths of one's heart recollect generosity; and from the depths of one's heart recollect the ultimate deity. One should read these in the same way, prostrate in the same way, and in the same way, from the depths of one's heart, individually confess and acknowledge. Counting from the first day, on the morning when six days have passed, one should again sprinkle with scented water and also wash the body with scented water.

"When they burn fine resin incense and make offerings wholeheartedly, and confess and acknowledge individually in this way from the depths of their hearts, the ten directions are roused. At that time, accompanied by immeasurable buddhas as numerous as the sands of the river Ganges and immeasurable bodhisattvas as numerous as the sands of the river Ganges, I will follow the sound of their voices, go into that chamber, and confer the empowerment of manifest accomplishment. If one does this for seven days

and nights, one's misdeeds will without doubt be purified.

"If one asks how one knows that the misdeeds have been purified: since ordinary beings have not yet accomplished the ultimate, one should examine the signs in dreams and omens. If one dreams one kind of dream, one act of immediate retribution is purified; if one dreams five kinds of dream, the five acts of immediate retribution are purified. If in a dream at night one wishes to cross a great river and dreams of going over a great bridge, one has certainly attained liberation. If in a dream one dreams that others bathe one and that rain falls on one's body, one has certainly attained what is utterly pure. If in a dream one dreams of entering into a great assembly of the Saṅgha and sitting in the row, one has certainly become a true disciple of the Buddha. If in a dream one dreams of entering a stūpa or a temple and seeing images of buddhas and bodhisattvas, one has entered the sublime gateway of the Dharma. If one dreams of finding fruit and eating it, it shows that the fruit of good qualities will be accomplished in this very life."

Again the Blessed One declared to Mañjuśrī: "If any monk, nun, novice monk, novice nun, or faithful bodhisattva, whose mindfulness has lapsed, has through error and delusion broken or damaged the moral discipline of the vows one by one, and then likewise individually confesses and acknowledges, it is impossible that the misdeeds should not be purified, except when it is not done from the depths of the heart."

Then Mañjuśrī asked the Blessed One, "Blessed One, when this rite is performed, is it permissible for there to be many people, or is it not?"

The Blessed One declared, "From one person up to twenty is permissible. While practicing this rite, one should not think of other sūtras. If, after confession has been made in this way, one commits no further wrongdoing from then on, that is what is called confession. Keep this in mind: 'We are now like those who have come back to life from death. Now I shall guard moral discipline. Now I shall practice diligence. Now I shall read and recite the sūtras of the Great Vehicle.' At that time, keep this in mind in this way, and think: 'From this day on, I aspire to hold the vows I have taken like a vajra, able to endure.' When one keeps this in mind in this way, the holy being Vimalakīrti, together with immeasurable bodhisattvas, stands before him and takes him into his charge. The noble Samantabhadra acts as the preceptor of his repentance. The noble Kāśyapa serves as the support before whom the request is made. Mañjuśrī, this is called purifying misdeeds. This is called

liberation. This is called possessing moral discipline. This is called attaining one's standing."

Again the Blessed One said this to the bodhisattva great being Mañjuśrī: "Suppose there is someone who has broken or damaged, one by one, the four roots, the eight vows, the partial vow, the ten precepts, going for refuge in the three, the five precepts, the ten virtues, moral discipline, and the Vinaya; or who has committed the five acts of immediate retribution; or who has committed the misdeed of disparaging equality. If that person does nothing but persist in wrong conduct and does not individually confess and acknowledge it, then as soon as he passes from this life he will without doubt fall into the hell of Avīci, the hell of no respite."

Mañjuśrī said, "Blessed One, why is it called the hell of no respite? For the sake of all sentient beings, may the Tathāgata please explain by what cause and what condition one falls into it, the shape and size of the hell, and for how many eons one remains in the suffering of karmic maturation."

When he had asked this, the Blessed One declared, "Mañjuśrī, that is very wise! That is very wise! To ask about such a matter is also very wise. Listen well, and let all the great multitude also consider it well. I shall explain it in detail.

"Why is it called the hell of no respite? It is called the hell of no respite because there is not even an instant of respite or pause in its torment. In one sense, it is called the hell of no respite because there is no stopping or escaping it and no change: the heat is intensely hot, the suffering is utterly unbearable, there is not an instant of leisure, not an instant of rest, and no interval. In another sense, it is called the hell of no respite because a great fire blazes there, intensely hot, blazing everywhere, blazing fiercely, spreading and penetrating within."

Again the Blessed One declared to Mañjuśrī: "Son of good family, the shape of the great hell of no respite is a square of eighty thousand yojanas. It is encircled by seven layers of iron walls and covered above by seven layers of iron nets, and below there are eighteen compartments. All around it, it is encircled by seven layers of sword forests. Inside the seven layers of iron walls there is a forest of trees with leaves of swords. The iron chambers of the eighteen compartments are stacked one upon another, in eighty-four thousand layers.

"At its four corners stand four great copper dogs. The size of their bodies is forty yojanas in height. Their eyes are like flashes of lightning, their fangs like sword trunks, their teeth like mountains packed with razors, their tongues like iron thorns, their claws like iron stakes, and their tails like iron snakes. From every single pore blazing fire spreads out fiercely, blazing everywhere and blazing intensely, and the stench of its smoke cannot be compared with any stinking thing in the world.

"At each of the four gates of that hell stand eighteen hell guardians. Their heads are the heads of rākṣasas, and their mouths are like the mouths of rākṣasas. On their heads they have eighteen horns, and in their hands they hold iron stakes. Inside the seven layers of walls there are countless iron banners, and fire bursts from the tops of the banners like water from a spring. A stream of molten iron pours down, flowing everywhere. Above each of the four gates of the hell there are eighteen great copper cauldrons, full of boiling molten iron, which spills from their mouths and pours down at the four gates, flowing in until it fills the hell. Inside each compartment there are also eighty-four thousand great iron snakes, which vomit venomous fire from their mouths and spew it until the walls are completely filled. The roar of the snakes is like a great clap of thunder. A rain of great iron balls also pours down, filling the whole of the hell of no respite.

"The unbearable sufferings there number eight billion. All the sufferings among sufferings, all the most unbearable among the unbearable, are gathered there, beyond compare. Outside each of the four gates of the hell of no respite, blazing fire spreads out fiercely, and the flames sweep south and north, east and west, crossing and meeting one another. The flames blaze from the iron walls all around, across eighty thousand yojanas, up to where they reach the iron nets above, flaring upward and flaring downward, above and below and in the four directions, blazing everywhere and blazing intensely, and the sufferings arise all at once, as was said above.

"Those who have broken the four roots and the eight vows, committed the five acts of immediate retribution, or disparaged equality, if they have not made confession as this sūtra sets out, and have no remorse or shame, then as soon as they pass from this life, in the time it takes a strong man to stretch out and bend back his arm, they fall into the hell of no respite. Their bodies fill it completely. Tormented by the heat and in agony, they open their mouths and shut their eyes, open their eyes and shut their mouths, but their mouths are stopped, and they cannot speak.

"Because his misdeeds are many, countless wheels of swords rain down from the sky. They strike him on the crown of the head and come out at his feet, and all the sufferings described above are multiplied hundreds, thousands, and tens of thousands of times. Whoever has broken all four of the roots completely experiences great suffering until five great eons have run their course. For breaking the eight vows it is greater than that by one more measure. For the five acts of immediate retribution it is also greater by one more measure. For disparaging the sūtras of equality it is also greater by one more measure. Cursing the Three Jewels, stealing the property of the Saṅgha, defiling the pure conduct of monks and nuns, domineering over one's preceptor and teacher, and committing sexual misconduct with one's mother all increase it by one more measure beyond those above. As for those of wrong conduct, because they have cut off their roots of virtue entirely, they never escape from Avīci; they alone are the exception.

"When such sinners as these experience their suffering, the blazing fire spreads fiercely and enters into them, and they swoon and die. Then the rākṣasa hell guardians strike the ground with their iron stakes and call out, 'Revive! Revive!' At the sound of the call they revive again and again, so that in a single day and night they die ten thousand times and live ten thousand times, experiencing great and unbearable suffering, as was taught above.

"When at last they come back out of Avīci, by the karma of having broken moral discipline and of having accepted the offerings of faithful patrons, they enter in turn the lesser hells. These are the hell of freezing cold, the hell of black darkness, the hell of intense heat, the hell packed with razors, the hell of the wheel of swords, the hell of fiery chariots, the hell of the mire of excrement, the hell of boiling water, the hell of the river of burning embers, the hell of the forest of trees with leaves of swords, the hell of iron machines, the hell of iron śālmali trees, the hell of iron couches, the hell of iron wheels, the hell of iron caves, the hell of iron balls, the hell of the crushing, colliding mountains, and the hell of poured molten copper. In each one of these they are tormented for eight million years before they are at last released. Even then they are always born in base conditions, and for five hundred lifetimes they do not hear even the sound of the Three Jewels. If by chance they meet a spiritual friend, they may perhaps give rise to the mind of awakening; if they do not meet a spiritual friend, they fall into hell once again.

"If one does not confess and acknowledge the misdeeds of minor wrongdoing, one will experience suffering in hell for eight million years, counted in the years of the gods of the Four Great Kings. Of these, the misdeeds of the downfalls produce twice that, and the saṅghāvaśeṣa offenses also produce twice that again. When those sinners experience their suffering, no other words come out of them; they only keep saying, āṃ pa pa, āṃ ta ta, āṃ la la, āṃ ba ba. Therefore, sinners, quickly confess and acknowledge each of your misdeeds, and go for refuge in the Three Jewels!

"Moreover, Mañjuśrī, it is like this: if you wish to clear away and purify misdeeds quickly, confess and acknowledge each of them as set out in this sūtra, and repent! Throughout the rite, for seven days and nights, eat only once a day, and with right thought and right mindfulness one should contemplate the names the Tathāgata bears when he attains buddhahood: the name Great Man, the name Manifest Awakening, the name Unmoving, the name Liberation, the name Radiant, the name Fully Developed Wisdom, the name Endowed with the Perfections, and the names of the ocean of samādhis such as heroic progress.

"In yet another way, the bodhisattva great being should rise from the samādhi of the sublime mind of loving-kindness and enter the samādhi of the cessation of mind. Rising from the samādhi of the cessation of mind, he should enter once more the samādhi of heroic progress.

"Rising from the samādhi of heroic progress, he enters the samādhi of the lamp of wisdom. Rising from the lamp of wisdom, he enters the samādhi of the characteristics of phenomena. Rising from the characteristics of phenomena, he enters the samādhi of the radiant sign. Rising from the radiant sign, he enters the samādhi of the lion's roar. Rising from the lion's roar, he enters the samādhi of the lion's stretch. Rising from the lion's stretch, he enters the samādhi of the ocean mind. Rising from the ocean mind, he enters the samādhi of universal wisdom. Rising from universal wisdom, he enters the samādhi of the seal of dhāraṇī. Rising from the seal of dhāraṇī, he enters the samādhi of the bodily form that appears everywhere. Rising from the bodily form that appears everywhere, he enters the samādhi of the realm of phenomena itself. Rising from the realm of phenomena itself, he enters the samādhi of the lion king. Rising from the lion king, he enters the samādhi of the Dharma king. Rising from the Dharma king, he enters the samādhi that stops the signs of the māras. Rising from stopping the signs of the māras, he enters the samādhi of the wisdom of emptiness. Rising from the wisdom of

emptiness, he enters the samādhi of knowing things as the characteristic of emptiness. Rising from knowing things as the characteristic of emptiness, he enters the samādhi of the wisdom of great emptiness. Rising from the wisdom of great emptiness, he enters the samādhi of the bodily form that pervades all places. Rising from the bodily form that pervades all places, he enters the samādhi of discerning the characteristics of mind. Rising from discerning the characteristics of mind, he enters the samādhi of the Vajra characteristic of the bodhisattva great beings. Rising from the samādhi of the Vajra characteristic of the bodhisattva great beings, he enters the samādhi of the Vajra crown. Rising from the Vajra crown, he enters the samādhi of all oceans. Rising from all oceans, he enters the samādhi of the ocean of all dhāraṇīs. Rising from the ocean of all dhāraṇīs, he enters the samādhi of the ocean of the sphere of activity of all the buddhas. Rising from the ocean of the sphere of activity of all the buddhas, he enters the samādhi of the ocean that sees the liberation of all the buddhas and the wisdom of liberation. Rising from the ocean that sees the liberation of all the buddhas and the wisdom of liberation, only then should he enter the gateway of the boundless and endless ocean of the samādhis of skillful means. Rising from the gateway of the boundless and endless ocean, he enters the samādhi of the cessation of mind and of peace. Rising from the cessation of mind and of peace, he should enter the samādhi of the great liberation, Vajra-like and certain.

"Mañjuśrī, after I have passed into nirvāṇa, any son or daughter of good family who gives rise to a mind of faith for a single instant, and writes out, reads, or recites this sūtra, keeping it in mind for an instant, and in whom the mind of faith is accomplished as a perception of reflection, a perception of recollection, and a perception of realization, will in an instant cast off the misdeeds of saṃsāra accumulated over eons as numerous as the sands of ninety hundred thousand koṭi-niyutas of Ganges rivers. The obscuration of ignorance too will be removed for good. Therefore it is evident that the Tathāgata lives on forever, sustaining himself and abiding, and does not pass into nirvāṇa."

Then the Blessed One spoke these verses to the great assembly:

"All the pretas of great power,
The savage elephant among the animals,
Lustful women and savage nāgas,
And the countless savage ones,
Vasu and Ajātaśatru,
Devadatta and Aṅgulimāla,

Because they did evil with body and mind,
Deserved to fall into the hell of Avīci;
Yet because they gave rise to faith
And paid homage to the Victors of the ten directions and three times,
When the Sage was about to pass into nirvāṇa,
Their fall was put off for countless eons.

"That all the people of Magadha
Gave rise to the mind of awakening
Was also by the power of paying homage with reverence
To the Victors of the ten directions and three times.

"That Kauṇḍinya and the others,
And the five hundred pure śrāvakas,
Will attain awakening in the future
Is also by the power of paying homage with reverence
To the Victors of the ten directions and three times.

"That non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) and brahmins,
The great mantra holders and the ten sages,
Have now attained arhatship
Is the reward of paying homage to the Victors
Of the ten directions and three times of the past.

"That they have realized the sublime meaning,
And that in the Victors' fields of the ten directions
All the hosts of bodhisattvas
Have been born with immeasurable life,
Is also by the power of paying homage with reverence
To the Victors of the ten directions and three times.

"Prince Seeing Virtue, it was like this.
Long ago, when I was a king,
I was called the great sage Giver.
At that time no buddha had appeared.
To five hundred brahmins
I gave food and clothing,
Houses and dwellings, and even bedding,
For a full twenty years,
Offering them the honors due to renunciants.

At that time I exhorted them:
'Give rise to the mind of awakening!'
Those five hundred brahmins,
Although they accepted the offerings I gave,
Had no faith in the Three Jewels,
And at once they answered me:
'In the world there is no awakening
And no liberation.'
When I heard them speak this way,
To protect the sūtras of equality,
I took the lives of the five hundred brahmins.
When those brahmins passed from that life,
They fell into the hell of Avīci.

"Having fallen into hell,
Those beings were stirred by three recollections
And paid homage to the Victors of the three times.
They gave rise to faith in the sūtras of equality,
In awakening, and in the Saṅgha,
And because they made the three recollections,
At once they came out of hell and went
To be born in the world called Drum of Sweet Nectar,
Where their life lasted ten minor eons.
That too was the reward of paying homage
With a reverent mind to the Victors of the ten directions.

"All those brahmins
First fell into hell through disparagement,
Yet afterward, through faith, were freed at once.
What need is there to speak of you bodhisattvas,
Who possess a sense of shame?
Because from the very beginning
Misdeeds have no intrinsic nature,
For the sake of sentient beings
The vows of the four roots,
The misdeeds of the five acts of immediate retribution,
Even wrong conduct, are confessed and acknowledged.

"If any ordinary person
Who has committed such misdeeds
Is able to confess and repent in the same way,
The misdeeds of the four roots, the five acts of immediate retribution,
And even wrong conduct are purified,
And attaining buddhahood is also certain.
Only those without faith are the exception.
Whoever gives rise to a mind of faith
And pays homage to the Victors,
It is impossible that he should not accomplish the path of the Dharma."

Then Prince Seeing Virtue
And the three thousand people
Spoke with one voice
And said this to the Blessed One:
"Once we have attained buddhahood,
We aspire to free all those in saṃsāra from birth and death.
Venerable One who dwells among gods and humans,
Please explain it in detail:
For those who hold this as a dhāraṇī,
Write it out, read it, and keep it,
How much merit will there be?"

The Blessed One declared:
"I shall explain it in detail.
Prince Seeing Virtue, listen well.
Suppose someone gives the seven kinds of precious substance
As gifts and offerings
To the beings who fill a thousandfold world,
And moreover teaches them the Dharma
And brings them to attain the fruit of arhatship.
If someone hears the name of a Victor,
Gives rise to a mind of faith,
And pays homage for a single instant,
His merit surpasses that.
What need is there to speak of writing it out, reading it, keeping it,
And paying homage with faith?
The merit of that is immeasurable.
Whoever writes it out,

Reads it and recites it,
And at the proper times pays homage with the mind aroused,
Has merit greater than that of building
Stūpas enough to fill a thousandfold world."

Then Mahākāśyapa,
Śāriputra and Ānanda,
The mighty world protectors,
The Brahmā gods and the Lord of the Gods (Indra),
The wheel-turning kings and the Four Great Kings
Bowed their heads at the Blessed One's feet
And with one voice said this:
"After the Blessed One has passed into nirvāṇa,
We shall spread and teach this
Widely among sentient beings.
So that their bodies and minds may always be happy,
We shall protect those who pay homage.
Whoever has broken the vows,
Committed the misdeeds of the five acts of immediate retribution,
Or disparaged equality,
By hearing the names of those buddhas
Will dwell happily on the pure ground.
Just like Prince Seeing Virtue,
In the time yet to come
They will see the nature of a buddha."

Then the Blessed One Śākyamuni said this to the great assembly: "Listen well! I shall explain to you the causes and conditions of deeds done in the past. Long ago, countless eons in the past, I heard the names of the buddhas of the ten directions and the three times from the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha called Beautiful Light. A mind of great joy arose in me, and joining my palms, I received them upon the crown of my head. Having received them, wherever sentient beings dwelt, I spread and taught them widely there to immeasurable, boundless sentient beings, and caused them to hear the names of the buddhas. At that time, among those assemblies, only three thousand people were in accord with the meaning of my Dharma. Giving rise to immeasurable faith, they recited the names of those buddhas in my presence and paid homage, and because of this they now appear in the ten

directions and attain manifest awakening.

"Sons of good family, if you wish to purify misdeeds up to the four roots, the grave misdeeds of immediate retribution, disparaging equality, and wrong conduct, you should come under the power of the mind of faith. Sons of good family, it is like this: those who, without faith and without reverence, disparage and abuse the twelve divisions of scripture, and disparage and abuse Vajra Body, the holy being Mañjuśrī, and the Victors of the ten directions, will without doubt fall into hell. This is no lie. Why is that? Because they have no faith; because they disparage the sublime Dharma; because they scorn the masters; because they revile the buddhas of the ten directions and the three times. They will certainly fall into hell. If one has faith in those names of the buddhas and pays homage from the depths of one's heart, it is impossible that one's misdeeds should not be purified, even those of the ten non-virtues, the five acts of immediate retribution, and disparaging equality. The exceptions are those without faith, those without reverence, those whose roots of virtue have been cut off, and those of wrong conduct.

"Sons of good family, the body of Śākyamuni is emanated a hundred hundred-thousand times, and in each world he acts as the Teacher and abides there. The last of these bodies is I. At that time, the three thousand people who accompanied me have all now attained buddhahood. The chief of the first thousand is the Buddha called Padmaprabha. The chief of the middle thousand is the Buddha called Vajra Body. The chief of the last thousand is the Buddha called Maitreya. Therefore it is fitting that you too, in the same way, recite the names of the buddhas of the ten directions and the three times and pay homage. In the future, teach this extensively to great assemblies and benefit boundless sentient beings. Recite it throughout the three realms, make a maṇḍala in a peaceful and secluded place, and become like me!"

Then the bodhisattva Dhāraṇīdhara rose from his seat, draped his upper robe over one shoulder, and placed his right knee on the ground. Joining his palms toward the Blessed One and paying homage, he said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, what is the name of this Dharma discourse? How should it be held? How should it be meditated upon and practiced?"

When he had asked this, the Blessed One declared, "Son of good family, hold this Dharma discourse by the name Benefiting Those with Grave Vows. Hold it by the name The Essence of the Vajra Jewel. Hold it by the name The Immeasurable Gateways of the Piṭakas. Hold it by the name The All-Inclusive.

Hold it by the name The Great Ornament Without Compare. Hold it by the name The Array of Three Thousand People Attaining Buddhahood. Hold it by the name Purifying Misdeeds through Repentance and Attaining Merit. Hold it by the name the Great Liberation Extending in All Directions."

Then the bodhisattva Dhāraṇīdhara said this to the Blessed One:

"Blessed One, as the Tathāgata has taught, this Dharma discourse, this sūtra that purifies misdeeds and brings about buddhahood in order to benefit immeasurable sentient beings and bring them great happiness, is the mother of all buddhas. It is the path of all bodhisattvas. It is the eye of the śrāvakas. It is the dwelling place of gods and humans. I shall retain this, which is endowed with such inconceivable meaning, as a dhāraṇī. Wherever gods and humans dwell, there I shall spread it widely. I shall make it endure for a long time without interruption."

The Blessed One declared, "Excellent, excellent! You are a holy being, one who retains all the immeasurable great piṭakas. In the future, go to the places where I go. Stay in the places where I stay."

When the Blessed One taught this Dharma discourse, countless bodhisattvas came to abide on the ground of irreversibility and immutability. Eighty thousand śrāvakas generated the resolve for the Great Vehicle. Ten thousand monks attained the fruit of arhatship. Eighty-four thousand gods and humans obtained the utterly pure Dharma eye. One hundred thousand sentient beings generated the resolve for unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

Then, when the Blessed One had finished teaching this sūtra, he went away from where the sāla trees stood. When he had gone, the golden flowers and the jewel pools also vanished, and the Tathāgata's light was withdrawn as well. The high and low places, the clean and the unclean, of the Sahā world were just as they had been before. And because humans commit misdeeds, the hells too were just as they had been before.

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the whole assembly of bodhisattvas, and the world with its gods, humans, asuras and gandharvas, rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had said.

This concludes the noble Great Vehicle sūtra called the Great Liberation Extending in All Directions: Purifying Misdeeds through Repentance, the Array of the Complete Attainment of Buddhahood.

Translated from the Chinese. Seven hundred and twelve ślokas, that is, two sections and one hundred and twelve ślokas.

Translator's Notes

• This sūtra has no Sanskrit title line and was evidently translated into Tibetan from Chinese. The bodhisattva □□□□□□□□□□, listed directly after Bhaiṣajyarāja, is here the companion bodhisattva Bhaiṣajyasamudgata (as in the Chinese pair Yaowang and Yaoshang), not the Medicine Buddha Bhaiṣajyaguru, so the house rendering was not used. Several bodhisattva names (Unwavering Light, Nāga Tree, King Lord of Dharma, Dhāraṇī Holder, Jewel Treasury, Ever Diligent, Never Ceasing, Faith in Characteristics, Invincible) could not be matched with confidence to Sanskrit forms and are translated by meaning.
• The phrase □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is read as □□□□□□ □□□□□□□□□□ ("that being so, here..."); "nad" (illness) makes no sense here and is taken as a copyist's slip. Vimalakīrti is called □□□□□□□□□□, rendered "the great being", apparently reflecting the Chinese dashi; this sūtra was translated from Chinese. The Buddha addresses Ānanda by the short form □□□□□□, which here refers to Ānanda, not Nanda. Śāriputra's recollection refers to the episode in the Vimalakīrti Sūtra where he worries about the meal.
• The phrase □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is read as □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ ("if it remains, all the lower realms will be closed off"), an evident copyist's slip that otherwise makes no sense. "Sūtra" in "the sūtra is the single vehicle" (□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□) may rather mean "in essence" (as □□□□□, "in short", earlier in the sentence); the literal reading is kept.
• Here □□□□□□, paired with Upananda as a nāga king, is the nāga king Nanda, not Ānanda as earlier in the text. □□□□□□□□□□ is taken as one item, "the mother Hārītī"; it could also be read as Hārītī together with the mātṛkā goddesses. The yakṣa general □□□□□□□□□ is identified as Saṃjñeya.
• The story of the ten thousand fish who are reborn among the Thirty-Three after hearing the name of Ratnaśikhin parallels the Jalavāhana episode of the Suvarṇaprabhāsa Sūtra; on that basis the king (Tibetan "Light of the Lord of Gods") is given as Sureśvaraprabha and the rescuer as Jalavāhana. The syllables preceding "Jalavāhana" in the Tibetan (dra ma) are unclear and have not been rendered separately. The first buddha of the litany, literally "Lamp Meru King," is rendered by meaning, as the Sanskrit form is uncertain. The line rendered "the words, which are seeds, by nature fall hollow" (sa bon tshig rnams rang bzhin dong) is obscure; the sense appears to be that the teaching does not take root in those without virtue. "Very nature of a buddha" renders sangs rgyas kyi bdag nyid.
• Apart from names with well-established Sanskrit forms (Candrasūryapradīpa, Dīpaṃkara, Prabhūtaratna, Amitābha, Amitāyus, Ratnarāja), the buddha names in this litany are rendered by meaning, since their Sanskrit forms cannot be identified with confidence. The "sixteen princes" are presumably the sixteen sons of the buddha Mahābhijñājñānābhibhū of the Lotus Sūtra, who all became buddhas. In "Fragrance of Tamāla Leaf and Sandalwood," the Tibetan ta ma ra ba ra appears to be a garbled spelling of tamālapattra. In "All-Pervading Golden Light," the element kun tu dgra ma is unclear and its rendering is tentative.
• As in the preceding litany, most buddha names are rendered by meaning, since their Sanskrit forms cannot be identified with confidence. Vipaśyin, Śikhin (gtsug tor can) and Viśvabhū (thams cad skyob) are the familiar buddhas of the past and are given in Sanskrit. "Prasenajit" follows the standard Sanskrit equivalent of gsal rgyal, here the name of a million buddhas rather than the king of Kosala. In the verse, "those who hold to the side of wrong conduct" renders log spyod phyogs su lta ba; the sense may be "those who hold wrong views."
• As in the preceding litanies, most buddha names are rendered by meaning. Kanakamuni

(gser thub), Kāśyapa, Vipaśyin, Śikhin, Viśvabhū, Akṣobhya (mi 'khrugs pa) and Maitreya are given in Sanskrit. In the run of names "Without Form as a Sign," "Scattered Form," "Without Sign of Smell," and so on, the series of sense objects suggests that "Scattered Form" (gzugs 'thor) may stand in place of a name concerning sound, but it is translated as written. "Sign of Indra" renders dbang po'i mtshan ma.

• The twelve divisions of scripture are given in this text's own order; they correspond to sūtra, vyākaraṇa, gāthā, geya, udāna, nidāna, avadāna, itivṛttaka, jātaka, vaipulya, adbhutadharma and upadeśa. "Introductory accounts" reads gleng gzhi for the written gling gzhi, an evident copyist's slip. "Four billion eons" renders bskal pa 'bum phrag bzhi khri, literally "forty thousand hundred-thousands of eons." Bodhisattva names without a confidently identifiable Sanskrit form are rendered by meaning; the four "Conduct" bodhisattvas recall the four leaders of the bodhisattvas from beneath the earth in the Lotus Sūtra, and Vimalagarbha and Vimalanetra are the two princes of that sūtra. "Never Empty" (stong med) is a tentative rendering.

• Most of these names could not be identified with confidence and are translated by meaning. □□□□□□□□ is read as □□□□□□□□, "Abiding in the Center," since □□□□ is not a meaningful syllable here. The sense of □□□□□□□□ in "Sound That Releases, Seizes, and Shakes the Mountains" is uncertain. Ratnamudrāhasta appears twice in the list, as it does in the Tibetan.

• Most of these names could not be identified with confidence and are translated by meaning. The name Fearless occurs twice, as in the Tibetan. The sense of □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, rendered "Preceptor Who Teaches," and of □□□□□□□□□□, rendered "Examiner of Giving," is uncertain.

• The large numbers are computed from the Tibetan: ten-thousand units counted in hundreds (one hundred times ten thousand is one million, up to a thousand times ten thousand, ten million), and hundred-thousand units counted up to ten thousand times ten thousand hundred thousands. "The Great Liberation Extending in All Directions" is the title of this sūtra itself. "Monks who had lost their minds" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ literally; it may mean monks whose minds had strayed or become confused.

• "Gods and demons" renders □□□□□□□□□, a stock Tibetan phrase for gods and harmful spirits in general. "In its very sphere" renders □□□□□□ (dhātu), the underlying sphere or nature of the Jewels. The "eight distortions" are, in the usual exegesis, the four mistaken views of ordinary beings (taking the impermanent as permanent, and so on) and the four mistaken views of śrāvakas about nirvāṇa.

• "They act as though they did not know it" renders □□□□□□, which is obscure here; the sense, confirmed by the later gloss on "not taking up reward or attainment," is that the bodhisattva forgoes the final attainment. "The others whom the bodhisattva has not yet liberated" interprets the terse □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□

the instrumental of the Tibetan; the agent who realizes the wisdom of the buddhas is left implicit. "Only as a figure of speech" renders bla dags su, a conventional or expedient designation.

• The word rendered "elder" is dra ma, an unusual term that the sūtra itself glosses as the Tathāgata; since this text was translated from Chinese, it probably renders a word for a respected elder or householder, but this identification is uncertain. "Worthy to receive offerings" renders yon 'ju ba, literally "to digest offerings," an idiom for being a fit recipient whose merit can bear what is offered.

• In the list of what the sūtra purifies, the Tibetan reads dam pa'i chos la bkur ba, "respecting the true Dharma," which makes no sense among evils to be purified; the translation follows the evident reading skur ba, "disparaging," which the text uses elsewhere in this same list. The names of the eons, the world, and the buddha Great Generosity are translated by meaning, since no Sanskrit forms can be identified with confidence, apart from Brahmaghoṣa. "One of wrong conduct" renders log spyod, apparently a class of morally fallen beings in this text translated from Chinese; its exact referent is uncertain.

• In the opening sentence, □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is taken as "the names of the buddhas," referring to the many buddhas listed in the preceding passage, rather than the major marks. In the verse on the twelve links, □□□□□□□ is read as □□□□□□□□ ("examining"), since "permanent" makes no sense in context. The name of the Tathāgata □□□□□□□□□□□□ is translated literally as "Unchanging Light," since its Sanskrit form cannot be identified with confidence.

• The list of thirty-two marks and their karmic causes is translated as this text gives it, including the apparent repetition of "even teeth" for two different causes; it is not harmonized with the standard lists. □□□□□□□□□ is taken as idle or frivolous talk. The passage breaks off mid-sentence and continues in the next piece.

• □□□□□□ and □□□□□□□, in the list of notions of a self, probably correspond to the Sanskrit manuja and mānava of the standard list; they are rendered literally here. The phrase □□□ is obscure; it is rendered as "showed liberation from the prison of the three realms and showed what is not the true fruit," which is tentative. □□□□□□ in □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is read as □□□□□□□ ("fully").

• In □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, □□□□□□ is taken as the Buddha's charioteer Chandaka and □□□□□□□ as describing the horse; the phrase could also mean that the horse itself is named (Kaṇṭhaka), so this reading is tentative. □□□□□□ and □□□□□□ are taken as Udraka and Ārāḍa, the Bodhisattva's teachers. The eon name □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is rendered "Thousandfold Utterly Pure"; □□□□ might instead mean "empty." The final verb □□□□ is unclear and is rendered "remains."

• The world in the east, □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, is rendered by its meaning, "Full Moon, Utterly Pure and Thoroughly Adorned," as its Sanskrit form cannot be identified with confidence. The numbers of laymen and laywomen follow the Tibetan exactly: □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ (400,000) and □□□□□□□□□□□□□ (1,000,000).

• "Seven days" renders the honorific □□□□□□□□□; it could also be read as "seven years," though the later instruction of seven days (□□□□□□□□□□) supports "days." The phrase "the countless many who are in training" takes □□□□□□ here as those undergoing training rather than the precepts themselves. The clause about "the enjoyment body and the rest" (□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□) is syntactically loose in the Tibetan, and its construal is uncertain. □□□□□□□□ is read as the evident □□□□□□□□, "confess." The name □□□□□□□□ could not be identified with a Sanskrit form and is translated literally as "Seeing Virtue."

• Several names could not be identified with a Sanskrit form and are translated literally: the buddha of the nadir, Hundred Thousand Reflections (□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□), and the great being of the nadir, Steadfast Glory (□□□□□□□□). Gandhakūṭa, Lokadhara and Pūrṇacandra are reconstructions from the standard equivalents of the Tibetan. "The all-seeing Avalokiteśvara"

renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□. □□□□ in "we constantly disparaged it" is read as the evident □□□□. The sense of □□□□□ ("deliberately") and of the clause about proclaiming worldly fruits of affliction is somewhat uncertain.

• "The eight kinds of unexamined possessions" (□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□) probably refers to the eight kinds of possessions improper for monastics; the exact list intended is uncertain. In the list of monastic rules, "the six" (□□□□) is given without further specification, and "the seven very weighty rules" follows the text's number, although the weighty rules (gurudharma) are usually counted as eight. □□□□□□ is read as □□□□□□□, "confess." The phrase translated "give them refuge or help" (□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□) is somewhat uncertain in its second member.

• □□□□□□□□ is rendered "cymbal," a small percussion instrument carried on the alms round; the exact implement intended is uncertain. In "having turned another's mind toward it" (□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□) the construal is uncertain. "Ten million" renders □□□□□□□□□□, a hundred times a hundred thousand.

• The verses explain the traditional epithets of the Buddha (Tathāgata, Arhat, Perfectly Complete Buddha, Endowed with Knowledge and Conduct, Sugata, Knower of the World, Charioteer Who Tames Persons, Unsurpassed, Teacher of Gods and Humans, Buddha). In "spent or unspent" (□□□□□□□□□□□) and "where the world is spent" (□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□), □□ is taken in the sense of "exhausted," which is uncertain. The prose after the buddhas' speech shifts to the first person singular ("me"), apparently the voice of Śākyamuni; the speaker is not marked. "The members of the assembly who were further off" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, whose sense is uncertain; "in accord with what has been taught today to the bodhisattvas" renders the obscure □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□.

• □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, "extensive," renders vaipulya and echoes the sūtra's own title. □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is the standard rendering of the śūraṃgama samādhi. □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is unusual (perhaps for □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, "the realm of reality"); translated as written. □□□□□□ in this list of offerings and ablutions is taken as scented water. The final verb □□□□□□□□□□□□ is read as □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, "confer the empowerment," an evident scribal slip. □□□□□□□□□ and □□□□□□□□□□□□, listed after monks and nuns, are taken as novices (śrāmaṇera, śrāmaṇerikā), as the parallel lists of the Chinese-derived sūtras suggest.

• □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, "disparaging equality," is translated as written; in the Chinese parallels of this rite the corresponding fault is slandering the Vaipulya (fangdeng) sūtras, which the Tibetan seems to have rendered as "equality." The phrase □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, literally "apart from wrong conduct," is obscure; it is rendered as persisting in wrong conduct without confessing. The sense of □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ (Vimalakīrti "takes him into his charge") and of □□□□□□□ (Kāśyapa as the one before whom the request is made, perhaps the officiating master) is uncertain. □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, "the partial vow," probably refers to a lay vow kept in part. The figure □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is eighty thousand times a hundred thousand, eight billion. □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is taken as "iron thorns," following the parallel imagery of this description.

• □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, rendered "greater by one more measure," most likely means each class of offense is one degree, perhaps twice, as heavy as the one before. The obscure closing clause about those of wrong conduct (□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□) is taken to mean they are the exception to eventual release from Avīci. The cries of the suffering beings are given as spelled. □□□ in the list of the Tathāgata's names could also be read as "marks." In □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□

parallel story of the king who killed five hundred brahmins to protect the Vaipulya sūtras, in which they are reborn in the world of the Tathāgata Amṛtadundubhi. The closing clause about the Tathāgata (□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□) is somewhat obscure; it is taken to mean that he lives on and abides. "The sūtras of equality" (□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□) appears to correspond to the Vaipulya sūtras of the parallels.

• In the verse □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, □□□□□□ ("pure") is read as □□□□□□□, "all those," since "pure ones" makes poor sense; □□□□□ here is simply "free." The Buddha □□□□□□□□□□□□ could not be identified with confidence and is translated as "Beautiful Light"; □□□□□□□□□□□□□ is likewise given as "Vajra Body." □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is obscure; "recite it throughout the three realms" is a tentative rendering. The bodhisattva □□□□□□□□□□ is taken as Dhāraṇīdhara.

• The final line counts the text's length: 712 ślokas, reckoned as two bampo (fascicles of 300 ślokas each) plus 112.

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.